



POLICE VISIT

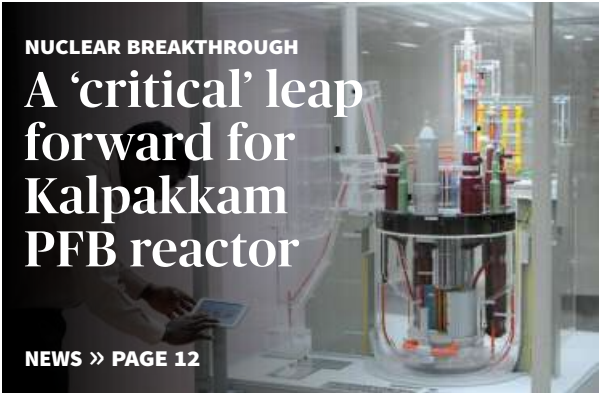
Assam CM's wife files case against Khera

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NUCLEAR BREAKTHROUGH

A 'critical' leap forward for Kalpakkam PFB reactor

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POST SC ORDER

NCERT reconstitutes textbook committee

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Dynamics of delimitation and women's quota

A rushed exercise could affect intended reforms

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THE ARCHITECT

Jaiswal in full flow as Royals go to the top

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People block a road in protest in Bishnupur district, Manipur, after two children were killed in a bomb attack on Tuesday. PTI

Renewed violence in Manipur leaves 4 dead

The Hindu Bureau
GUWAHATI

Four people, two of them minors, were killed in renewed violence in Manipur's Imphal Valley on Tuesday.

Officials in Bishnupur district said two children – a five-year-old boy and a six-month-old girl – were killed and their mother injured when suspected extremists hurled a bomb at their house in the Moirang Tronglaobi area around 1 a.m. The low-lying Meitei-

inhabited area is close to the hills of the Kuki-Zo-dominated Churachandpur district.

The killings triggered protests, and a mob attacked a Central Reserve Police Force camp close to Tronglaobi.

Manipur Home Minister Konthoujam Govindas said five sustained bullet injuries (in firing by the security forces), and two of them died later.

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Bengal electorate shrinks 12% as 27 lakh out after judicial reviews

Latest exclusions take total names deleted from the rolls in the poll-bound State since SIR began to 91 lakh; highest number of voter deletions after adjudication in Muslim-majority Murshidabad district, followed by North 24 Parganas and Malda

Shrabana Chatterjee
Shiv Sahay Singh
KOLKATA

Over 27 lakh West Bengal voters who were put under adjudication were excluded from the electoral rolls following the completion of the judicial reviews on Tuesday, with over a quarter of such deletions occurring in two Muslim-dominated districts.

In all, 91 lakh names have been deleted from the State's voter list since the special intensive revision (SIR) began, meaning that West Bengal's electorate has shrunk almost 12%, from 7.66 crore electors in October 2025 to 6.75 crore now, days ahead of the Assembly election. In the Assembly election in 2021, 7.34 crore voters were eligible to cast their ballot.

Falling numbers

The table shows the top-five (red) and bottom-five (blue) West Bengal districts in deletion of voter names that were under adjudication for 'logical discrepancies'



Choice on the line: People whose names were deleted from voters' lists queue up to present their cases before judicial officers in Nadia, West Bengal, on Tuesday . PTI

District Name	Deletions
Murshidabad	4,55,137
North 24 Parganas	3,25,666
Malda	2,39,375
South 24 Parganas	2,22,929
Purba Bardhaman	2,09,805
Purba Medinipur	19,572
Bankura	6,533
Purulia	5,942
Kalimpong	2,407
Jhargram	1,240

27.1 lakh voters under adjudication were removed from electoral rolls

91 lakh electors were removed from voter rolls in West Bengal since October last year

■ Highest number of deletions was recorded in the Muslim-majority Murshidabad district, and the Bangladesh-bordering North 24 Parganas district

SOURCE: ELECTION COMMISSION OF INDIA

About 63 lakh electors were removed from the voter list under the SIR in the State till February 28. In addition, 60.06 lakh were put under adjudication; of these, 27.16 lakh, or 45%, remained excluded on

Tuesday, according to data shared by the Chief Electoral Officer of West Bengal. The highest number of such deletions was in Murshidabad, the district with the highest percentage of Muslim population in West

Bengal. Of the 11.01 lakh names from the district which went for judicial scrutiny over the past few weeks, over 4.55 lakh were excluded. North 24 Parganas, a district which borders Bangladesh and sends

the highest numbers of MLAs to the Assembly, has registered deletion of about 3.25 lakh electors under adjudication, followed by Malda, another Muslim-dominated district, with 2.39 lakh deletions.

Last chance

The fate of the 27 lakh excluded voters now lies with 19 appellate tribunals set up across the State, and people started thronging them even before the exclusion list was released. However, for this election where polling is held on April 23 and 29, these voters have run out of chances to exercise their franchise.

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'HOW CAN POLLS BE FAIR?'
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'Earthset' boulevard



The other side: An 'earthset', where earth dips beyond the lunar horizon, as seen from the Orion spacecraft of the Artemis II lunar flyby mission on Monday. The four astronauts on NASA's flyby mission on Monday marked the furthest humans have been from the planet. AFP

A civilisation will die in Iran if deal not accepted, says Trump on 'deadline' day

Stanly Johny

U.S. President Donald Trump on Tuesday threatened that "a whole civilisation will die" if Iran does not accept his deal and re-open the Strait of Hormuz before his 8 p.m. Eastern Time (5.30 a.m. on Wednesday in India) deadline. Tehran, in turn, issued a warning that its response would deprive the U.S. and its allies of oil and gas for years.

U.S. Vice-President J.D. Vance, who is in Hungary, said his country has "tools in our toolkit that we so far haven't decided to use" against Iran, without elaborating further. The White House later said Mr. Vance did not mean use of the nuclear weapons. Respond-



Iranian children in Tehran on Tuesday mark 40 days since the fatal strike on a girls' primary school during the ongoing war. REUTERS

ing to a post on X that said Mr. Vance implies the President would use nuclear weapons, the White House Rapid Response said: "Literally nothing @VP said here 'implies' this, you absolute buffoons".

Iran's UN representative, Amir-Saeid Iravani, said Mr. Trump's threats

"constitute incitement to war crimes and potentially genocide", adding that "immediate and proportionate" action will be taken if the U.S. President follows through on it.

If the U.S. "crosses red lines, Iran's response will extend beyond the region", Iran's Revolutionary

Guards (IRGC) said in a statement. "Iran will attack the infrastructure of the U.S. and its partners that will leave the U.S. and its allies deprived of oil and gas in the region for years," it said.

The statements came as Tehran reported the U.S. and Israel had already begun attacking key infrastructure including bridges and railways.

Iran's Mehr news agency also reported that U.S. and Israel carried out strikes on Kharg Island in the Persian Gulf, which is a key export terminal for Iran's oil and gas.

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'HUMAN CHAINS'
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Supreme Court begins review of 2018 Sabarimala judgment

Krishnadas Rajagopal
NEW DELHI

Justice B.V. Nagarathna, the sole woman judge in the Supreme Court and part of the Constitution Bench hearing a reference spurred by a 2018 judgment upholding the right of women of menstruating age to enter the Sabarimala shrine in Kerala, said on Tuesday that social ills cannot be branded and passed off as 'essential religious practices'.

The Union government, which holds the position that the Sabarimala judgment was an intrusion into free exercise of religious freedoms and denominational rights, said the legislature, not courts, drives



reform in religion, if need be.

"If social evils are given a religious colour, then the courts can intervene to distinguish [between] the two," Justice Nagarathna said.

Solicitor-General Tushar Mehta, who opened the arguments before the nine-judge Bench headed by Chief Justice of India Surya Kant, said the Preamble to the Constitution champions liberty of thought, expression, belief, faith, and worship.

The exchange marked the first day of hearing of a reference to evolve a 'judicial policy' for constitutional courts while dealing with questions of right to religious freedom enshrined in Article 25 and a denomination's privilege to manage its own religious affairs under Article 26 of the Constitution.

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Rajesh B. Nair
PUDUCHERRY

As campaigning for Thursday's Assembly election in Puducherry came to an end on Tuesday evening, reports from the ground suggest that many constituencies have tilted towards an intense multi-cornered contest, with the outcome becoming increasingly unpredictable.

There are a total of 294 candidates – 34 from national parties, 63 State parties, 80 registered unrecognised parties, and 117 Independents – in the fray.

The parties in fray include the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP), the Congress, All India N.R. Congress (AINRC), Left parties, Dra-



Winding down: Senior BJP leader and Union Minister J.P. Nadda flagging off a bike rally on the last day of campaigning in Puducherry on Tuesday. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

vida Munnetra Kazhagam (DMK), All India Anna Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam (AIADMK), Viduthalai Chiruthaigal Katchi (VCK), Pattali Makkal Katchi (PMK),

Naam Tamilar Katchi (NTK), Tamilaga Vettri Kazhagam (TVK), and the Latchiya Jananayaga Katchi (LJK).

The poll scene in Pudu-

cherry was largely dominated by the two fronts – the National Democratic Alliance (NDA), comprising the AINRC, the BJP, the AIADMK, and the LJK and the INDIA bloc, comprising the Congress, the DMK, and the VCK.

The Union Territory has 9,50,630 electors spread across the Puducherry, Karaikal, Mahe, and Yanam regions.

The electorate size ranged from a minimum of 21,053 (Raj Bhavan constituency) to a maximum of 42,884 (Villianur constituency).

Many past elections in the Union Territory too were multi-cornered, largely due to the presence of Independents having a

strong local influence. However, this time the contest has become more intense in several constituencies with the entry of the TVK, headed by actor-politician C. Joseph Vijay, and the division within the INDIA bloc.

What has greatly altered the battlefield this time are the profiles of a few candidates the TVK, a fledgling political party, has fielded.

It has entered into the fray two sitting MLAs. One of them, Sai J. Saravanan Kumar, was a Minister in the incumbent AINRC-BJP government.

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LEADERS MAKE FINAL DASH
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Meghna M.
CHENNAI

T. Ramakrishnan
TIRUNEVELI

INBRIEF



Over 1,700 students graduate from IGNOU Regional Centre

A total of 1,789 students from the Chennai Regional Centre of the Indra Gandhi National Open University (IGNOU) graduated at its 39th Convocation on Tuesday. K. Panneerselvam, Senior Regional Director, IGNOU, said that about 210 programmes are offered in this region. S. Vincent, Member-Secretary, Tamil Nadu State Council for Science and Technology, said IGNOU’s programmes bridged the urban-rural divide to a great extent. Earlier, the 39th Convocation was kicked off in New Delhi by the Vice President, C.P. Radhakrishnan, and was live streamed simultaneously to 51 regional centres.

Ex-VHP leader R.B.V.S. Manian acquitted in hate speech case

The Principal Sessions Court on Tuesday acquitted former Vishwa Hindu Parishad (VHP) leader R. Balavenkata Subramaniyan, widely known as R.B.V.S. Manian, who was arrested by Mambalam police for an alleged hate speech at a public event in T. Nagar on September 13, 2023. He was arrested based on a complaint by a VCK member alleging that Mr. Manian’s speech attempted to lower the image of Babasaheb B.R. Ambedkar and made insinuating remarks against SC/ST people, in addition to containing derogatory remarks against VCK leader Thol. Thirumavalavan. Pronouncing the judgment, Principal Sessions Judge S. Karthikeyan acquitted Mr. Manian and said he was found not guilty of charges cited by the prosecution.

Forest officer arrested for accepting bribe in Tiruvallur

The Directorate of Vigilance and Anti-Corruption (DVAC) has arrested a forest officer for taking a bribe of ₹50,000 from a woman for issuing a licence related to timber trade near Uthukottai in Tiruvallur district. The police said the complainant, Shanthi, 40, a resident of Pullarambakkam near Tiruvallur, has been involved in the business of purchasing and selling red sanders. She approached Saravanan, the officer, who demanded ₹1 lakh as a bribe to issue the licence to carry out her trade. Unwilling to pay, she approached the DVAC officials in Tiruvallur and lodged a complaint. On Monday, when Shanthi handed over the money to the officer at the forest office, a team of DVAC officials caught Saravanan.

Sheen of this temple town is overshadowed by rising traffic congestion and civic challenges

Improved traffic management, additional parking spaces and better solid waste management are some of the immediate needs of residents; farmers oppose the Parandur airport project fearing loss of livelihood and damage to the environment

CONSTITUENCY WATCH

Sunitha Sekar
 CHENNAI

After a near two-hour drive on the Chennai-Bengaluru Highway, a glimpse of the top tiers of Ekambareswarar Temple greets you. By the time you navigate a maze of traffic and enter the core of Kancheepuram, the eyes brush past half a dozen temples. The town displays ancient heritage in all its grandeur dotted by multitude of temples and swarm of textile showrooms exhibiting their silk sarees.

Urban pressure

But the shine, sparkle and splendour end there. The temple town, which has been experiencing swelling population and a surge in tourists, is stretched and struggles to cope with this increasing burden. From increasing traffic congestion, unorganised parking and encroachments to sewage issues, Kanchipuram district, which will soon house the city’s massive second airport, still only bears a semi-urban character. For a town that has a tremendous potential to be so much more if better initiatives to promote tourism were implemented, little has been done in all these years.

While those coming to a few temples and shop for silk sarees have it anything but easy due to inadequate parking and congestion, the residents face an even bitter deal.

K.S. Krishnamurthy, a resident of Kancheepuram for several decades, said during the weekends and festivals, the traffic congestion turns worse.

Kancheepuram

A constituency dotted by historic temples and traditional silk weavers

KEY ISSUES

■ Heavy traffic congestion during weekends and festivals

■ Unorganised parking poses severe inconvenience to residents and tourists

■ Sewage leakage and overflow occur in some areas

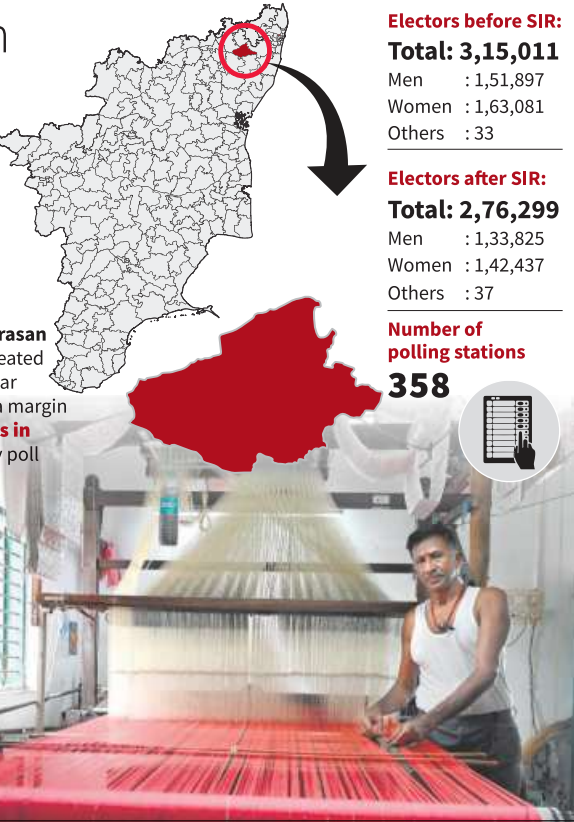
■ Weavers grapple with insufficient wages and rising raw material costs

Craft in decline:

A silk weaver said many in the profession have quit due to paltry wages, seeking better opportunities. M. SRINATH



C.V.M.P. Ezhilarasan of the DMK defeated P. Magesh Kumar of the PMK by a margin of **11,595 votes** in 2021 Assembly poll



Electors before SIR:

Total: **3,15,011**

Men : 1,51,897

Women : 1,63,081

Others : 33

Electors after SIR:

Total: **2,76,299**

Men : 1,33,825

Women : 1,42,437

Others : 37

Number of polling stations

358

tion turns worse. “Vehicle movement should be banned on the streets around the temple, and those lanes should be exclusively reserved for pedestrians,” he said.

He noted that while Kancheepuram got the underground sewage system nearly five decades ago, these sewer lines have turned ancient. “It is time to replace them. The lines are handling more than their capacity. As a result, we see leakages and overflows every now and then,” he said.

Improved traffic management, additional parking spaces and better solid waste management are some of the immediate needs of this temple town.

Weavers’ concerns

Civic issues aside, in the narrow lanes of the town,

skilled artisans who practice the timeless craft of silk weaving said they grapple with many issues including a meteoric rise in prices of raw materials to inadequate wages.

Kumaravel, a silk weaver, said, the district housed thousands of weavers once upon a time, but the number has diminished significantly. Many have left this profession due to lesser wages and better opportunities. “If we weave two sarees a month, we get paid ₹7,000. This doesn’t suffice. For instance, if they work in a company, they would get around ₹500 a day. So, naturally, many have begun to prefer that over this,” he said. They weavers do not find continuous work, which is another reason for their dwindling numbers in the district.

This constituency will soon witness a massive change when the development of the second airport for Chennai city at Parandur is completed.

Staunch opposition

While one part of the Parandur airport project falls under Kancheepuram constituency, the other is in Sriperumbudur.

The airport, set to be built over 5746.18 acres of land at ₹27,400 crore in four phases, is designed to handle 100 million passengers in future. But the farmers and residents of the villages in and around Parandur, who will be displaced, have staunchly opposed the project. They have been holding protests for a long time due to concerns over losing their livelihood and the environmental impact of the

Timings

CHENNAI

WEDNESDAY, APR. 08

RISE 06:01 SET 18:21
 RISE 23:44 SET 10:18

THURSDAY, APR. 09

RISE 06:01 SET 18:21
 RISE 00:00 SET 11:11

FRIDAY, APR. 10

RISE 06:00 SET 18:21
 RISE 00:33 SET 12:04

Chennai Weather	max	min
Tiruvallur	35	27
Chennai Airport	34	29
Chennai City	32	29

Chennai Airport Today
 36°C Morning will be comfortable. Day will be very warm. Night will be comfortable. Chances of light rain and thundershower.

Chennai Airport Tomorrow
 36°C The weather will be dry. Day will be very warm. Night will be comfortable.

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THE HINDU
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Narada Gana Sabha Trust
 Ph: 24993201
 Today Mini Hall (Swami Hari-dhos Giri Hall) - Nadasangamam - Talent Promotion Concert - 5:30 pm - Arvind Balaji, R Srikritii, G Prem Krishnan, 7 pm - Gayatri Mani, S Subhasree, Anirudh Raj. All are welcome.

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THE HINDU

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GENERAL

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GENERAL

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INBRIEF



Thilagavathy assumes charge as CGM at BSNL Chennai

D. Thilagavathy, an officer of the 1989 batch Indian Telecommunication Service, assumed charge as Chief General Manager, BSNL Chennai Telephones, on April 6. A B.Tech. graduate in Electronics and Communication Engineering from the College of Engineering, Guindy, she began her career with the Steel Authority of India (SAIL) in 1990 for a short period. As the Chief General Manager (CGM), Chennai Telephones, she will lead the organisation's strategic growth and infrastructure development in Chennai.

Four persons arrested for abducting, assaulting youth

Four persons were arrested by the city police for allegedly abducting a 19-year-old youth from Koyambedu and assaulting him with wooden logs. The police arrested Rithika alias Rithu, 21, Sanjay, 22, Darshini, 19, and Saravanan alias Motu, 20. The police said the victim, Sasikumar, had demanded that Rithika return the money, a total of ₹1.87 lakh, that he lent to her. Promising to return the amount, Rithika and her associates took Sasikumar in a vehicle to a spot in Tambaram where they assaulted him. The gang escaped after throwing him near a drainage. After regaining consciousness, Sasikumar informed his father over the phone and was admitted to KMC Hospital, where he is undergoing treatment. Based on a complaint, the CMBT police registered a case. An investigation was carried out and the four persons were arrested. The police also seized the car and an iPhone used in the crime. They said efforts were on to arrest the other absconding suspects involved in the case.

Poor delivery of schemes, lack of support for the farm sector are major talking points

Farmers say that during the peak season, the DPCs find it difficult to process and move the large volume of paddy that they deposit there. Payments are often delayed too, sometimes for over a month to three months. Irulars in the constituency say they face stigmatisation and live in abject poverty

CONSTITUENCY WATCH

Saptarshi Bhattacharya
CHENNAI

“When welfare schemes don't reach the last mile, it is always the under privileged who are deprived,” says J. Thiruvengadam, pensively.

An office-bearer of the farmers' body in Kamsalapuram village in Madurantakam Taluk, Mr. Thiruvengadam has a straight take for the candidates seeking election from the Madurantakam Assembly Constituency in the upcoming polls: “You tune your machinery to reach the tail end, you will ensure that benefits trickle down to subsistence farmers, those with minor landholdings, and those rearing livestock.”

Although barely 100 km from the capital city of Chennai, Madurantakam is a predominantly agrarian region with rice being the primary crop, while a section of farmers in Vayavoor region grow vegetables as well.

The Agriculture Department does make several facilities, like equipment and seeds, available to the farmers, but it is not always what they want. “The farmers are often torn between what they want and

Madurantakam (SC)

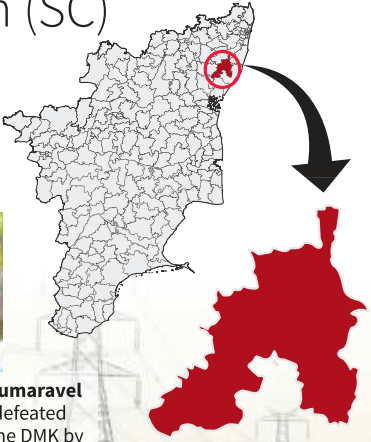
About 80 km south of Chennai, this constituency is predominantly inhabited by agrarian communities. The narrative here is shaped by delivery of government schemes to support farming

KEY ISSUES

- Government schemes often don't percolate down to those who need them the most
- Slow intake in the Direct Procurement Centres during peak season, often leading to delayed payments for farmers
- Most of the Irular families haven't been given pattas



Maragatham Kumaravel of the AIADMK defeated C.E. Sathya of the DMK by a margin of **3,570 votes** in 2021 Assembly poll



Electors before SIR:
Total: 2,29,635
Men : 1,12,185
Women : 1,17,359
Others : 91

Electors after SIR:
Total: 2,11,295
Men : 1,03,943
Women : 1,07,288
Others : 64

Number of polling stations
274



No options: Farmers complain that the Agriculture Department provides them seeds that are not of their choice, but they reluctantly accept them. J. JOHAN SATHYADAS

what they are offered. Sometimes, the department procures a variety of seed which is not the seed of choice for the farmers. Many reluctantly accept what is being offered,” Mr. Thiruvengadam added. “The department sometimes offered 100 power tillers, but the demand would be much more. Invariably, farmers with smaller landholdings lose out in the race.”

K. Damodaran of Veera-

nakunnam village agrees, adding: “The MLA brings us schemes, but the delivery of those schemes depend on the efficiency of the panchayat ward members. If they implement the schemes partially while claiming to have completed the work, it does not benefit the people but only those in power. When they come seeking votes, we will ask them tough questions.”

The Direct Procurement

Centres (DPCs) set up by the Tamil Nadu Civil Supplies Corporation to procure paddy directly from the farmers are often overburdened during the peak season.

Payments delayed

J. Damodaran, a farmer from Vayavoor, says, “During the peak season, the DPCs find it difficult to process and move the large volume of paddy that farmers deposit there. Pay-

ments are often delayed too, sometimes for over a month to three months. It would be great if steps are taken to process this faster.”

Farmlands in Madurantakam receive water through a network of over 500 irrigation tanks, the largest of them being the Madurantakam Lake. It irrigates over 2,500 acres of land spread across 10 villages.

Spillway constructed

It was recently spruced up, and a controlled spillway was built with 12 shutters to control the excess water discharge during heavy inflows.

A large number of farmers also depend on wells to water their crop, which makes the monsoon a crucial factor. Their main crop season is between December and March.

While the constituency has a sizeable Scheduled Caste population, two per cent of its population are tribals, especially the Irulas, a particularly vulnerable tribal group known for their deep knowledge of snakes.

Many of them continue to face stigmatisation and live in abject poverty. With barely any landholdings, they often find themselves outside the ambit of government schemes meant for the underprivileged.

“A few of us have been

given *pattas*, but most of us live in makeshift shacks covered with tarpaulin sheets, palm fronds and other dried up foliage,” says S. Prakash.

After completing school, he has been taking up odd jobs in farmlands nearby to supplement family income.

“These are low-lying areas and we are forced to shift to evacuee camps in the nearby school during monsoon,” he adds. There have been discussions to rehabilitate them to *patta* lands nearby but it's yet to be implemented.

Political past

Politically, it is one of those constituencies where both the Dravidian giants have won almost equal number of times. This time, the sitting AIADMK MLA, K. Maragatham, is seeking re-election while the DMK has fielded S. Ponmalar.

The field has been made interesting by the entry of the TVK candidate, E. Ezhil Catherine, who is the daughter of former Union Minister Dalit R. Ezhilmalai. The Naam Tamilar Katchi has fielded Janakiraman as its candidate.

In 2021, the AIADMK had a washout in the KTCC (Kancheepuram, Tiruvallur, Chengalpattu, and Chennai) region with Madurantakam being the only constituency where it set a foot at.

After scrutiny of nominations, candidates and supporters resume campaigning across city

FIELD POSITION

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

Despite being the hottest day this summer, tense moments were witnessed at offices of Returning Officers on Tuesday. By evening, the final numbers were out and candidates whose nominations were accepted, and their supporters continued their campaigning with great gusto.

A total of 628 nominations were filed in the 16 Assembly constituencies in Chennai, of which 462 were accepted. In Tiruvallur district, a total of 171 nominations were accepted and 167 were rejected in the 10 constituencies.

In Kancheepuram district, 75 nominations were accepted and 50 were rejected in the four constituencies. Chengalpattu district saw 238 nominations in the seven constituencies, of which, 130 were accepted.

AIADMK candidate M.K. Ashok who is contesting from the Velachery Assembly Constituency has been campaigning in various



Poll fever: AIADMK candidate M.K. Ashok campaigning in Velachery on Tuesday. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

parts of the constituency, covering Besant Nagar, Adyar, and Thiruvannmiyur, since filing his nomination.

Mr. Ashok, who is contesting for the third time, had won the newly-created Velachery Assembly seat in 2011. However, in 2021, he lost the seat to the incumbent MLA Aassan Maulana of the Indian National Congress.

Mr. Ashok, canvassing for votes in the west Velachery area on Wednesday, announced that the election promises made by AIADMK leader Edappadi K. Palaniswami would be fulfilled.

The candidate, who has the ‘son of the soil’ tag against outsider Maulana, went on a walk in the A.G.S. Colony and M.G.R. Nagar, canvassing for votes, stating

that he would take steps to prevent flooding by improving the stormwater drain facility. He also pointed out that the long-pending demand for renovating the Velachery lake would be taken up.

‘Looking for a change’

In Tiruvottiyur, Naam Tamilar Katchi candidate P. Sathya said, since people were

looking for a change in governance, they welcomed her. “We tell people of our poll promises, including putting an end to the drug menace, ensuring jobs for locals and taking steps to protect the environment. Wherever we go, people listen to us and respond well,” she said. Her supporters, like in other political parties, have been distributing pamphlets with their party's poll promises.

Kumar of the DMK in Sholinganallur constituency said, “We have to cover the entire constituency. In a few days the candidate will visit all the homes. I only visit homes that I know.”

In Chepauk-Thiruvallikeni, Aadhi Rajaraman of the AIADMK who is taking on Deputy Chief Minister Udhayanidhi Stalin, said that he knew the problems of the constituency very well. Fishermen, who form a sizeable portion, have been badly affected by various schemes including the Blue Flag beach project. Their livelihoods are at stake. Conservancy workers and the Brahmin voters are all against the DMK, he said, adding that he will win the seat.

Bus conductor found dead in sewage canal at Koyambedu

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

The police have begun an investigation into the death of a 51-year-old bus conductor working with the State Express Transport Corporation after his body was discovered in a sewage canal near the Koyambedu depot on Monday.

The deceased, identified as S. Vincent John Kennedy, 51, hailed from Rayanpatti in Tiruchirappalli.

According to police, passersby spotted him in the sewage canal located behind the SETC depot. Depot workers later pulled him out, but he was found to be dead. Upon receiving in-

formation, a team from the CMBT police station reached the scene, recovered the body and sent it to Kilpauk Government Medical College Hospital for a post-mortem examination.

The police have registered a case and are probing the circumstances that led to Kennedy's death.

DGP directs police not to violate hierarchy

S. Vijay Kumar
CHENNAI

Tamil Nadu Director General of Police and Head of the Police Force Sandeep Rai Rathore has directed district Superintendents of Police not to take instructions from police officers who were not in the chain of command.

In a note to senior police officers across the State, Dr. Rathore said district SPs and those in Special Units had been receiving

instructions related to official work from various officers who were not in their direct chain of command.

He asked the supervisory officers to report such matters of transgressions to him.

Mr. Rathore also instructed officers heading Special Units and Law & Order to immediately communicate to him and their immediate superiors any important issue developing within their respective jurisdictions. In case of

paucity of time or connectivity issues, they could even drop a message through messaging platforms.

‘Enforce poll code’

In a video-conference held with all Zonal Inspector-Generals of Police, Commissioners of Police and SPs, he said all steps in compliance with the Model Code of Conduct should be taken to ensure a free and fair election. Elaborate security arrangements were

imperative in the run up to the elections, more so, with VIPs travelling across the State, police sources said.

Reviewing the preparedness of the force for the polling on April 23 and counting of votes on May 4, Mr. Rathore called for intensified vigil in places with a history of violence during elections and along inter-State borders to prevent the movement of suspicious persons, liquor and cash, sources said.

EAST CENTRAL RAILWAY

E-TENDER NOTICE

(Pt. Deen Dayal Upadhyaya Division)
E-TENDER NOTICE NO.: - SG-DSE-OT-08-26
Name of work with its location: Alteration in Kyosan make E.I at Pusauli Station due to Yard remodelling for increasing CSL of DN loop and provision of second loop and shunting neck in UP Loop to eliminate shunting in mainline. 2. Approx. Cost of the work: Rs. 2,71,32,321.21/- (Two Crore Seventy One Lakh Thirty Two Thousand Three Hundred Twenty One and Paise Twenty One only). 3. Earnest Money: Rs. 5,42,700/- (Five Lakh Forty Thousand Seven Hundred only). 4. Closing date & time for Submission of e-tendering : 27.04.2026, Up-to 12:30 hrs. 5. Website particulars where complete details of tender can be seen etc.: www.ireps.gov.in
Divnl. Signal & Telecom Engineer
East Central railway, DDU
PR/0026/DDU/SA/TT/26-27/32

OBITUARY & REMEMBRANCE

DEATH

With deep sorrow, we announce the passing of

Dr. C.S. SANKARI (M.D.),
our Dotchimma

who left us peacefully on 6th April at Adyar, Chennai.
Final rites 9th April, 12.00 Noon.

She is lovingly remembered by her family, friends, and all whose lives she touched.
9840144710

DEATH ANNIVERSARIES

FIFTH ANNIVERSARY

Shri.D. Vasudeva Rao
Managing Director (Retd.)
Ennore Foundries Limited
11-09-1933 - 08-04-2021
Fondly remembered by
Anand, Narendar, Arvind and Family.

DEATH ANNIVERSARIES

Twelfth Anniversary

V. MOHANKUMAR
Fondly remembered by
Wife and Children

6th ANNIVERSARY

Shri. P.R. IDUMBAN
08.04.2020
Fondly remembered by
Family Members

DEATH

We are immensely grieved to announce the sad demise of

Shri Gajanand Saraf

05.03.1935 - 06.04.2026

National Oxygen Limited
Chennai

In Memoriam

Prof. K. S. Ganapathy
M.A., Ph.D.
08-04-2013

INBRIEF



Book on provisions of Income Tax for non-profits launched

Madras High Court Judge C. Saravanan launched the book ‘Income Tax provisions for NPOs - Journey from 1961 to 2025’ written by R. Ramachandran, at a function held in the city on Tuesday. The book was released on behalf of the All India Federation of Tax Practitioners (AIFTP). D. Sudhakara Rao, Principal Chief Commissioner of Income Tax (Chennai) received the first copy of the book. Commissioner of Income Tax (Appeals) S. Maruthu Pandian and Commissioner of Income Tax (Exemptions) J. Premanand, also spoke on the occasion.

Man held for stealing mobile phone from hotel cashier

A man was arrested for allegedly stealing a mobile phone from a hotel cashier in Aminjikarai under the pretext of making an urgent call. The arrested was identified as Ayyappan, 30, a former car driver of the hotel owner. Based on cashier Selvakumaran’s complaint, the police investigated and arrested Ayyappan.

Text & Context and Science

Weekday features on *The Hindu* epaper (epaper.thehindu.com) carry explainers, special articles and quizzes. In the latest issue (April 8, Wednesday), the following articles are available:

- On India’s updated climate pledges newsth.live/climatepledges
- Making sense of the science in ‘Project Hail Mary’ and its alien world newsth.live/projecthailmary

You can use your smartphone’s inbuilt features to access these articles. If it’s an Android phone, use Google Lens to read and tap the url to access an article. If it’s an iPhone, use Live Text on camera to do the same.

Community participation along with Exnora’s initiative breathe life into waterbodies

To bridge the gap in finding machinery for rejuvenation of waterbodies, the organisation has launched the rent-free excavator initiative; it currently executes nearly 15 projects in districts

WATER WATCH

K. Lakshmi
CHENNAI

Timely access to machinery and funding for it often remains a key challenge in restoring water bodies. In a concerted effort with government departments, Exnora International has been deploying rent-free earthmoving machines to rejuvenate water sources across various districts while also mobilising community participation. Finding machinery is often a roadblock to water bodies’ rejuvenation. To bridge the gap, the organisation launched the rent-free excavator initiative to empower communities to protect water resources. The movement for water management with people’s participation is now spreading across Tamil Nadu and helping revive water resources faster, said Senthur Pari, president, Exnora International. The organisation currently executes nearly 15 projects in districts, including Ariyalur, Kancheepuram, Villupuram, Vellore, and Tiruvallur, engages in a water literacy programme for residents and encourage them to volunteer and contribute funds to the projects, he



Rejuvenated resource: The long-neglected Thulukkankulam in Murugampakkam near Tindivanam now has water after volunteers and the local community desilted the pond after nearly five decades.

said. The long-neglected Thulukkankulam, a pond in Murugampakkam near Tindivanam, now has water after volunteers and the local community desilted the pond after nearly five decades. T. Panneerselvam, a car mechanic by profession, took the initiative along with a team of youngsters to rejuvenate the pond with the help of government agencies and Exnora.

Desilting work “We carried out desilting work for nearly 20 days in the nearly 3.5-acre pond. Groundwater table is within a depth of 30 feet of the pond. It is the source of groundwater recharge and agriculture. We have formed a team to maintain the pond,” said Mr. Panneerselvam who recently got permission from the

district collectorate to restore 12 more ponds with community participation. Similarly, residents and activists have rejuvenated the nearly 160-acre Muthampalayam lake in Villupuram district. N. Manikandan, activist who coordinated the project, said residents were successful in removing agrarian encroachments at a 50-acre portion of the lake. “We desilted and cleared sewage from the lake with the support of government agencies and like-minded organisations like M.N. Gayathri Charities. Local residents also crowdfund resources to sustain efforts to strengthen the bund and create islands in the lake,” said Mr. Manikandan who has coordinated initiatives to rejuvenate 15 water bodies and five water channels across six districts over the past six months. Exnora International aims to sustain the community-driven model by sourcing 38 rent-free excavators to be used across all districts with support of various stakeholders, including corporates. V. Subramani of Waterbody Exnora, said “We have restored about 100 water bodies, including in Chengalpattu, in the past two years. We identify residents’ groups enthusiastic about renovating water bodies and channels and support with machinery.” Besides earthmoving machines, Exnora also has weeder machines to ensure comprehensive restoration of a water body and its channels. Major waterways like Tamirabharani and Noyyal river are also cleaned with farmers’ participation, he added.

Health risks emerge earlier, stay hidden for long: Apollo report

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

India’s health landscape is rapidly and silently shifting, with the most common health risks emerging earlier and often remaining undetected. Findings from the ‘Health of the Nation 2026’ (HoN 2026) report by Apollo Hospitals, which is based on over three million preventive health assessments conducted across its ecosystem in 2025, indicate that risk factors for conditions such as diabetes and obesity were already present across younger and working populations, often before they were clinically recognised.

The sixth edition of HoN, which was released on World Health Day on Tuesday, said one in five persons under 30 were prediabetic. It is still reversible at this stage. Among those who intervened, 28% went back to normal. Among those over 50, only 7% did. It found that more than half were obese, and more than half had abnormal cholesterol. The report noted that nearly seven in 10 persons were deficient in Vitamin D, and close to half had low Vitamin B12. An early screening by Apollo Shine Foundation across 20,164 students aged 17 to 25 found that two in three had at least one underlying health risk. Prathap C. Reddy, founder chairman, Apollo Hospitals, said for too long, health checks were viewed

as routine blood tests and vitals merely a reactive response driven by fear. “Since no two lives are the same, our approach to prevention must be as individual as the people we serve,” he said. Giving women-specific insights, the report said women show distinct risk patterns, including anaemia and increasing central obesity with age. Based on Apollo’s data, the mean age of breast cancer detection through routine mammography was 51, nearly a decade earlier than in Western populations. Preetha Reddy, executive vice-chairperson, Apollo Hospitals, said estimates suggest that closing women’s health gap could add up to \$1 trillion annually to the global economy by 2040. “Yet, our data show that women in India continue to carry a significant health burden that often goes undetected,” she said. Healthier persons had more diverse gut bacteria. As conditions such as diabetes, obesity, and high cholesterol build up, gut diversity dropped by about nine per cent in those with multiple issues. Sangita Reddy, joint managing director, Apollo Hospitals, said that the right health check at the right time can detect heart disease and cancer at Stage 1, when they are most treatable. Chennai reported 25% diabetes, 26% hypertension, 38% anaemia, and 77% obesity among those screened, the report said.

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SESSION LINE-UP

APRIL 11, SATURDAY

Discovering Engineering: A Complete Guide to TNEA Counselling Procedures
Dr T Purusothaman
Senior official, Directorate of Technical Education (DoTE), Tamil Nadu

Choosing Medicine as a Career: Pathways & Growth Opportunities
E Tharanirajan
Additional Director of Medical Education and Research, Tamil Nadu

Default Life to Dream Life: Crafting a Career That's Uniquely Yours
Prof. T Thyagarajan
Pro-Vice Chancellor, VIT Chennai

Careers in Aviation: Pathways Beyond the Cockpit
Dr R Asokan
Dean of Aeronautical and Aerospace Engineering - HITS

APRIL 12, SUNDAY

Career Counselling in the Age of Emerging Technologies
Jayaprakash Gandhi
Career Consultant,

How to Crack JEE & NEET
Prof. A Ravishankar
Expert Professor Mathematics, Ahaguru

Degrees + Skills = Success: The New Formula for Career Growth
Dr G Selvakumar
Director – Engineering & Scientific Research and Strategic Collaborations, Vinayaka Mission's Research Foundation (VMRF), Chennai Campus

APRIL 11, SATURDAY

Navigating the Quantum Future - Education and Career Pathways
Dr Maheswari R
Principal - Rajalakshmi Institute of Technology

Core Engineering in the Modern Era: Relevance and Career Prospects
Dr MS Haji Sheik Mohammed
Dean - School of Infrastructure, B.S. Abdur Rahman Crescent Institute of Science and Technology, Vandalur, Chennai.

Skills Over Degrees: Redefining Career Success in the AI-Driven Economy
Dr Raghavan Santhanam
Director – School of Ports, Terminal Management & Logistics

APRIL 12, SUNDAY

Becoming a Chartered Accountant: Your Path to a Successful Career
CA Rajendra Kumar P
Central Council Member, ICAI

Skill Development and Industry Expectations from Students
V Udaya Sankar
Director, NASSCOM Talent Council, Co-founder, Maatram Foundation

Future of Work & Learning in the AI Era
Rajiv Tandon
Chief Executive Officer – BITS Pilani Digital

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Two plus one

Anti-incumbency is not a strong factor in two States and one UT going to polls

Public campaigning for the April 9 Assembly elections in Kerala, Assam and Puducherry concluded on Tuesday and voting will take place in a single phase across all three regions – 126 seats in Assam, 140 in Kerala, and 30 in Puducherry. The results will be declared on May 4. In Kerala, the incumbent LDF led by Chief Minister Pinarayi Vijayan is seeking a third consecutive term. No alliance has achieved such a feat in the State, but the LDF mounted an audacious campaign premised on a claim that ‘there is no alternative’ to the LDF. The emergence of the BJP – it won its first Lok Sabha seat in the State in 2024 – as a notable force in the State has further confused the Kerala electorate. Each of the three formations has accused the other two of having an understanding beneath the open posturing. The UDF is attempting to convert the momentum that it gained in the Lok Sabha and local body elections into an Assembly victory. The LDF is counting on its 10 years of welfare governance. The Congress has replicated its model of guarantees covering key vote blocs such as college students and women. The party managed to resolve the internal disputes over ticket distribution, but senior leaders are angling for the Chief Minister’s post, counting their chickens before they hatch. The CPI(M) had to contend with at least four of its senior leaders leaving the party and contesting as UDF candidates.

In Assam, the campaign has been dominated by Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma, who is seeking a second term and a third for the BJP-led NDA. He has formulated a strident version of anti-Muslim rhetoric, Hindutva, and indigenous identity politics and welfare schemes, particularly the Orunodoi direct benefit transfer to around 40 lakh women. Other promises by the BJP are measures against illegal encroachment, implementation of the Immigrants (Expulsion from Assam) Act, a Uniform Civil Code excluding tribal areas, and two lakh government jobs. The campaign concluded with the Congress responding in kind to Mr. Sarma’s highly personalised campaign against Congress’s campaign leader Gaurav Gogoi. Mr. Sarma has been alleging that Mr. Gogoi has links with Pakistan. The Congress alleged that Mr. Sarma’s wife holds three passports – the UAE, Antigua and Barbuda, and Egypt – and may be preparing to flee in the event of defeat. A six-party alliance led by the Congress is fighting on an uneven battlefield in Assam. In Puducherry, an NDA government led by All India N.R. Congress (AINRC) leader N. Rangasamy has been in power since 2021. With only 30 seats, the personal standing of individual candidates could play a bigger role in the outcome than grand politics in the Union Territory.

Systemic reckoning

Sattankulam verdict should sensitise the police against use of excessive force

Delivery of justice to hapless victims of police brutality requires a combination of an actively engaged judiciary, the courage of victims and witnesses to speak out against the khaki fraternity, and a determined investigation to assemble irrefutable evidence. All these factors perfectly aligned to uncover the truth behind the custodial killing of an innocent trader, Jayaraj, and his son Benicks, who were tortured at the Sattankulam police station in Thoothukudi, Tamil Nadu, six years ago. Relying on the CBI’s scientific evidence, despite early attempts to destroy it, a trial court in Madurai has now convicted all nine policemen arraigned in the case. A tenth accused had died earlier of COVID-19. While the awarding of the death penalty to the convicts militates against the principle of rehabilitative justice, the conviction sends a strong message to those in uniform who assume the power to wield force against unarmed citizens as if it were a statutory right. This case might have passed off as yet another suspicious custodial death but for overwhelming evidence of torture and public outrage. The police picked up Jayaraj on false charges of violating lockdown conditions during the pandemic, and Benicks was detained later when he confronted them for assaulting his father. The two men were stripped, brutally beaten overnight, and even forced to clean their own blood with their clothes. After registering an FIR on trumped-up charges, the injured men were produced before a government doctor, who dubiously issued a “fit for remand” report. The jurisdictional magistrate too mechanically remanded them to judicial custody, ultimately leading to their deaths.

That the policemen felt entitled was evident when a Judicial Magistrate found the atmosphere at the station hostile and “intimidating”. Justices P.N. Prakash and B. Pugalendhi of the Madurai Bench of the Madras High Court, having taken *suo motu* cognisance, in an extraordinary direction, asked revenue officials to take control of the station to safeguard evidence. The turning point came when a head constable, Revathi, testified against her colleagues. The CBI established that blood samples recovered from the station matched the victims’ DNA, while call data records confirmed the presence of both the victims and the accused at the time of the crime, sealing the case. The trial court appears to have applied uniform proportionality in assigning culpability to all accused. This may not withstand scrutiny in higher courts, as seen in the Rajiv Gandhi assassination case, where the Supreme Court, in 1999, upheld the death sentences of only four of the 26 convicted by the TADA court. Nonetheless, the convictions should help sensitise the police force that excesses will not go unpunished.

In September 2023, Parliament passed the Constitution (One Hundred and Sixth Amendment) Act, 2023, or the Nari Shakti Vandan Adhiniyam, which commits to reserving one-third of seats in the Lok Sabha and Vidhan Sabhas for women, including in constituencies already earmarked for Scheduled Castes and Scheduled Tribes. However, this potentially transformative measure falls short of immediacy: its implementation is deferred until after the next Census and the subsequent delimitation exercise.

During parliamentary debates, the Congress party, along with several other Opposition parties, demanded its immediate operationalisation, ideally for the 2024 general election. Women’s rights groups criticised the government for tying the quota to delimitation after the new Census, arguing that it creates unnecessary delays. The National Democratic Alliance (NDA) government rejected this, maintaining that such a major change, without updated Census data and delimitation, would undermine both fairness and feasibility.

The shift now seems more deliberate

Less than three years later, that position appears to have shifted. Recent reports suggest that the government now plans to amend the Women’s Reservation Act, 2023 by initiating a delimitation exercise based on the 2011 Census, rather than waiting for a fresh Census and a subsequent delimitation process tied to it. At the same time, the size of the Lok Sabha and State Assemblies may be expanded by nearly 50%, increasing the Lok Sabha’s strength from 543 to 816 seats. In the absence of any formal articulation of the basis for such an expansion, questions arise about its implications for representational balance and political fairness.

Taken together, these developments – particularly the proposed increase in seats – point to a decoupling of women’s reservation from the next Census, expected to include caste enumeration beyond the Scheduled Castes and Scheduled Tribes, and the delimitation exercise that would follow. While this shift is framed as a means of expediting implementation, it also suggests a more deliberate political reconfiguration underlying these far-reaching structural changes.

The timing is telling. Acting at this juncture allows the government to claim credit for a long-pending reform that previous administrations failed to implement, even if it entails departing from the sequencing that it had earlier defended. It has clear electoral implications, likely to mobilise women voters in upcoming Assembly elections across key States/Union Territory, consolidate support ahead of the 2027 contests, and position the Bharatiya Janata Party as the party that delivered on women’s reservations and gender justice. This claim could, in turn, become a chief plank of its campaign for the 2029 general election.



Zoya Hasan

Professor Emerita,
Centre for Political
Studies, Jawaharlal
Nehru University

Implementing women’s reservation without waiting for the Census or delimitation exercise could undermine representation and the intended reforms

Delimitation, however, remains contentious, questioning whether representation should be based solely on population or also consider economic, social, and demographic factors. A strictly population-based approach would strengthen the parliamentary power of northern States where fertility rates remain relatively high, while reducing the relative influence of southern and peninsular states that have stabilised population growth and significantly drive India’s economy and employment. This dynamic is likely to deepen the existing north-south divide, driven by demographic asymmetries and uneven development outcomes, placing additional strain on the federal compact and the balance of inter-State representation.

These conflicting concerns stem from the constitutional freeze on delimitation, leaving constituency boundaries and seat allocations unchanged since the early 1970s. After nearly five decades, the government now appears set to lift this freeze, proposing a roughly 50% expansion of the Lok Sabha alongside proportional increases in State Assemblies. This approach is intended to reassure southern States by preserving their relative share of seats and thus reducing resistance to delimitation. Yet, even with a uniform expansion, the absolute seat counts of northern States would rise significantly, further tilting the existing balance of power in their favour. For instance, Uttar Pradesh and Bihar together could approach 180 seats, while the five southern States (Karnataka, Kerala, Tamil Nadu, Andhra Pradesh, Telangana) combined may reach around 195, raising the possibility that the northern bloc could still wield disproportionate political weight. In a first-past-the-post system, where numerical strength ultimately determines both electoral victory and seats gained, such an increase risks entrenching structural disadvantages for less populous regions, even if formal proportionality is preserved.

The issue of data

These distributional concerns are compounded by the question of data. Basing women’s reservation on the 2011 Census is problematic, particularly when a new Census is already underway. India in 2026 bears little resemblance to its 2011 demographic profile: migration, rapid urbanisation, and the after-effects of the COVID-19 pandemic have significantly reshaped population patterns over the past decade and a half, altering both urban and rural constituencies. Proceeding with outdated data risks misrepresenting current realities at the very moment when foundational decisions on delimitation, seat expansion, and the operationalisation of women’s reservation are being made. Yet, the urgency to move ahead suggests a calculated political judgement: that the imperative of delivering women’s reservation will outweigh resistance, as few can afford to oppose its expeditious implementation, leaving little

A closer look at Asim Munir’s West Asia diplomacy



Mahesh Sachdev

Former Indian
Ambassador
specialising in West
Asia and oil matters

Pakistan’s Field Marshal is being watched to see whether he will emerge as an indispensable mediator or a useful idiot

Pakistani diplomacy has left no stone unturned in wooing Trump 2.0, flipping a decade-long mutual antipathy with the U.S. that followed the killing of Osama bin Laden in 2011. Indeed, this multi-pronged charm offensive has been handsomely rewarded, and Asim Munir has become Mr. Trump’s favourite Field Marshal. Then moving on to being a messenger-cum-mediator between Washington and Tehran, seamlessly replacing Oman and Qatar, as the latter faced Iran’s retaliation for hosting the U.S. military bases.

An overreach

In Asim Munir’s scheme of things, all this greater realpolitik is to set off a perpetual motion machine meant for multiple ends. In the short run, he hopes to monetise its “peace-making” role to curry favour with both Washington and Beijing, becoming a useful conduit for their planned first Summit next month. He would also attempt a reset with the post-war dispensation in Iran. Islamabad has already leveraged its putative links with Iran to host a brainstorming meeting with the Foreign Ministers of Saudi Arabia, Türkiye and Egypt on March 30, which may lead to an Islamic NATO. In a less noticed, but significant move, Asim Munir recently paid a low-key fence-mending visit to Abu Dhabi, miffed by Islamabad’s growing proximity with rival Saudi Arabia.

At a different level, Islamabad also hopes that its overreach would fulfil its long-standing ambition to be counted in the senior league of the Islamic world. Last, but not least, Pakistan also hopes that being the paw of various fat cats would earn it cash rewards and bail it out of perennial penury. If all that happens, Asim Munir would have transformed himself from being an ambitious top-gun to surpass the iconic Ayub Khan, the only other Field Marshal and President of Pakistan.

room to contest either the process or its sequencing. The issue is further complicated by what the next Census itself may reveal. Widely expected to be a landmark exercise, the availability of caste data could sharpen demands for greater representation of disadvantaged caste groups, particularly given their demographic strength. It may also amplify calls for sub-quotas within women’s reservation, especially from Other Backward Classes (OBCs), including Muslim OBC communities that remain underrepresented. Several political parties and women’s organisations have already voiced such demands. By moving ahead without waiting for the 2026-27 Census, the government appears to be postponing these pressures, but only temporarily.

A further concern is the lack of clarity on how women’s reservation will operate in practice. While the amendment mandates a one-third quota, it defers critical details, especially the rotation of reserved constituencies. This is not a minor issue: rotation determines who can contest, from where, and with what continuity, shaping both accountability and constituency development. Earlier proposals cautioned that frequent rotation could disrupt these goals, yet the current framework leaves the design unresolved. Reports suggest that in smaller States and Union Territories with one or two Lok Sabha seats, the rotation of reserved constituencies may operate differently, resulting in less frequent turnover, while in larger States, some seats could remain reserved across successive terms. However, the law itself provides only for rotation after delimitation, leaving the precise mechanism to be defined.

The need for deliberation

None of this diminishes the core premise: women’s reservation is long overdue and politically imperative. Evidence from other countries suggests that quotas can be effective, and there is little reason to believe that India would be an exception. Taken together, women’s reservation, seat expansion and delimitation are not isolated changes; they will jointly reshape who is represented, from where, and in what proportions. Seen in this context, they mark a foundational reordering of the electoral map – one that will redraw constituencies, recalibrate the weight of States, and reconfigure the social composition of legislative bodies. Far from a marginal or technical adjustment, this is a structural shift that could rebalance political power across regions, social groups, and genders.

Precisely because of the scale of this shift, implementation must be preceded by thorough deliberation grounded in the latest data. Departing from the logical and constitutionally settled sequence risks distorting representation and seat distribution, thereby weakening the very reform it seeks to advance. India stands on the cusp of one of the most significant transformations of its representative system since the early decades of the Republic.

There are reasons to believe that Asim Munir’s diplomatic activism may not get sustainable tailwinds to fully realise its goals. It is mainly because too many factors are beyond his control. Well-informed U.S. media reported last evening that Iran has stopped engaging in talks to halt the fighting. It may turn out later that sceptics in Tehran were cynically “blowing hot, blowing cold” about the “Islamabad talks”, to keep Mr. Trump off-balance and expose his unreliability as a regional security provider. This could take the wind out of Pakistan’s self-image as the only country with cordial ties with both Iran and the U.S.

There are multiple ethnic, geopolitical and orientational differences between Tehran and Islamabad. Second, the portents do not point to any possible de-escalation in the conflict, which currently seems headed in the opposite direction. The current prognosis is for either a war of attrition or for Mr. Trump to declare a fictional victory and quit the arena.

The broader view

Either way, Iran may use the leverage of the selective closure of the Strait of Hormuz to serve its own multiple goals, from revenue accretion to keeping the littoral states under pressure and forcing the U.S. to relent on the sanctions. In either of the two scenarios, the stakeholders would have little use for Asim Munir’s diplomacy. Pakistan’s long restive land border with Iran and a significant Shia minority have forced its hand in being more kinetic in response to Saudi Arabian calls for mutual defence. In case Mr. Trump averts his eyes to the Gulf and looks for more manageable targets, his ardour for his favourite Field Marshal may cool further. This would then allow the redoubtable Pakistani Field Marshal an opportunity to rue the verity of a century-old aphorism: “War is too important to be left to the generals”.

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

Forever wars

An Israeli peace activist recently described Gaza, Iran and Lebanon as fronts in “one forever war”. That phrase captures a tragic truth many prefer not to confront: these conflicts are no longer isolated eruptions of violence but parts of a continuous, self-sustaining

cycle driven by fear, retaliation, political survival, and hardened narratives on all sides. Each round of fighting is justified as necessary, defensive, and unavoidable. Yet, every strike plants the seeds of the next. Civilians pay the highest price while leaders speak in the language of

security, deterrence, and survival. What makes this “forever war” so dangerous is not only the destruction that it causes but also the way that it reshapes thinking. It convinces societies that peace is naive, that empathy is weakness, and that perpetual conflict is the

natural order. Voices calling for dialogue, and political courage are often dismissed as unrealistic. Yet, history shows that “forever wars” end only when people dare to imagine an alternative and demand that leaders pursue it.
Jagjit Singh,
Los Altos, California, U.S.

Sattankulam case

The well-reasoned judgment in the Sattankulam case brings closure to a gruesome murder which was committed with impunity by those who are expected to uphold the law, procedures and guidelines related to interrogation.

That the CBI took painstaking efforts to establish the offence merits commendation of a high order. The sanctity of human rights has prevailed.
V. Johan Dhanakumar,
Chennai

Letters emailed to letters@thehindu.co.in must carry the postal address.

Limits of neutrality in addressing caste

The interim stay by the Supreme Court on the UGC Promotion of Equity in Higher Education Institutions Regulation, 2026, as reported by the Supreme Court Observer, arrives at a pivotal moment. These regulations emerged from *Abeda Salim Tadvi v Union of India*, a pending case before the Supreme Court concerning caste-based discrimination and student suicides in higher educational institutions. The case highlights institutional failures in creating an equal and inclusive learning space.

When discussing caste discrimination in higher education, it is essential to clarify what is being addressed. The 2026 regulations under 3(c) define “caste-based discrimination” as discrimination based on caste or tribe against members of the Scheduled Castes, the Scheduled Tribes, and Other Backward Classes. This specificity is not exclusionary; rather, it is necessary to recognise caste as a continuing structure of marginalisation rather than isolated incidents.

Why neutrality fails
The definition has been criticised for excluding ‘general category’ students, with suggestions to adopt a caste-neutral definition that includes them, in line with Article 14 of the Constitution, which guarantees equality before the law. However, this reasoning misunderstands both how caste discrimination operates in practice and how equality is understood under the Constitution.

The Constitution does not mandate an abstract, one-size-fits-all neutrality. Article 15 not only prohibits discrimination but also empowers the State to make “special provisions” for socially and educationally backward classes, SCs and STs to ensure substantive equality. Equality, in this framework, is substantive rather than formal.



Priya Chaudhary
Research Associate,
CLPR

The UGC guidelines must be supported by monitoring, regular audits, and meaningful oversight

Formal equality assumes that discrimination operates symmetrically and that all social groups require identical protection. However, caste discrimination is structural, embedded in graded hierarchies that shape access to dignity, resources, and institutional power. Including “general category” groups into a caste-neutral definition risks collapsing this structural inequality into a universal grievance framework, where systemic oppression is equated with isolated interpersonal bias. Such neutrality does not expand protection; it dilutes the law’s ability to address caste as a system of power.

For decades, SC and ST students have experienced social exclusion, unequal treatment, humiliation, and institutional bias. In several cases, such structural discrimination has led to mental distress and suicides. These realities, reflected in the pending case under which the equity regulations were formulated, show that the framework is grounded in systemic concerns, not isolated incidents.

A caste-neutral definition would flatten unequal social positions into a formal notion of sameness that the Constitution itself does not endorse. Articles 14 and 15 permit differential treatment precisely to remedy historical and social disadvantage. Treating caste-based oppression as symmetrical across groups disregards the hierarchies through which caste operates and shifts the focus away from structural exclusion to abstract individual grievances. Therefore, defining caste-based discrimination through historically marginalised groups is not arbitrary. It recognises that discrimination operates through power structures that advantage some while disadvantaging others. This is not “reverse discrimination,” but an acknowledgement that equality requires fairness in practice. A caste-neutral approach would obscure these structural

realities and weaken the law’s capacity to address caste-based exclusion in higher education.

Enforcement matters more
The equity regulations in higher education, including a focused definition of caste-based discrimination, are not meant to exclude others from protection. Rather, they aim to create a baseline of dignity and inclusion for those who have historically been excluded. This approach aligns with Articles 14 and 15, which allow differential treatment to remove disadvantage and achieve substantive equality. In a society shaped by caste, constitutional equality cannot be achieved through context-blind neutrality.

More importantly, the question is how effectively they may function on the ground. The failure to address caste-based discrimination lies largely in weak implementation and poor institutional accountability.

Instead of diluting the scope of the UGC regulations, the focus should be on strengthening them – by ensuring independent complaint mechanisms, time-bound inquiries, transparency in outcomes, and clear consequences for institutional non-compliance. The UGC guidelines must be supported by monitoring, regular audits, and meaningful oversight. A framework meant to prevent caste-based harm cannot succeed unless institutions are made answerable for how they respond to discrimination in practice.

Shifting the debate away from enforcement and towards abstract concerns about neutrality risks missing the core issue. For students facing everyday exclusion, the question is not inclusive definitional purity, but whether the system will respond when discrimination occurs. Strengthening the functioning of the UGC framework is therefore essential to fulfilling the constitutional promise of equality and dignity in higher education.

Kerala polls ignore a Gulf lifeline at risk

Kullu Thamam hides a looming disruption to remittances and livelihoods

STATE OF PLAY

Rejimon Kuttappan

As Kerala heads to the polls on April 9, a glaring paradox looms over the State. This is a land defined by migration. For generations, lakhs of Keralite families have built their homes, hopes, and futures on the salaries earned by sons, husbands, brothers, and fathers in the Gulf. The remittance economy is not a side story in Kerala’s development; it is the story.

Lifeline under threat

Today, that same lifeline is under threat. Since late February, the escalating Iran-U.S.-Israel conflict has turned Gulf airspace into a dangerous theatre of missiles, drones, and interceptors. Airports in Dubai have been hit. Missile debris has landed in residential areas of Manama. Air routes have been suspended, forcing thousands of Indians into exhausting overland journeys through Saudi Arabia.

Indian workers have reported watching drone strikes from their apartment windows. Constant safety alerts and sirens restrict their movements. Many have been forced to stop work without clarity on whether the leave is paid or unpaid. Companies are openly warning workers that salaries will be delayed, halved, or withheld until the crisis ends. Recently hired workers are also being terminated.

Over 2.2 million Keralites live and work in the Gulf. Yet this war is almost absent from the election campaign. Neither the Communist-led Left Democratic Front nor the Congress-led United Democratic Front has issued any serious policy statement on the crisis.



Kerala’s political class continues to treat the Gulf as Delhi’s foreign policy matter, even though it is the most critical domestic issue for the State.

Why has this life-and-death crisis failed to become a poll issue? The answer lies in two uncomfortable truths.

First, a powerful narrative of false reassurance has been carefully built. In the Gulf, Indian businessmen with vested interests, along with large sections of the Kerala media, keep repeating the phrase *Kullu Thamam* (All is well). Gulf governments ‘announcing’ investments, businessmen saying no panic, and Kerala media outlets reliant on Gulf advertising downplay the crisis, focusing on safety systems while ignoring wage cuts, food prices, and growing fear.

But *Kullu Thamam* is a dangerous half-truth. Small business owners are struggling to pay wages, parents are worried about children’s education, and low-paid workers are facing sharply higher prices for Indian vegetables due to disrupted supply routes.

Illusion of calm

Second, currently, most families continue to receive their monthly remittances. As long as the cash flows, the distant war feels like someone else’s problem. But this calm is deceptive and dangerously so.

In 2023-24, Kerala received \$23.4 billion in inward remit-

tances, the second-highest among Indian States after Maharashtra. Yet the real story lies in how deeply these inflows sustain the State. Remittances account for a staggering 17.1% of Kerala’s GDP, the highest share among major Indian States and more than three times Maharashtra’s 5%. By comparison, the national average stands at just around 3%.

This is not just another economic statistic. It means that nearly one-fifth of Kerala’s entire economy is directly powered by money sent from the Gulf. Entire towns and villages, real estate booms, gold sales, educational institutions, and daily consumption all float on these remittances. When that lifeline falters, the impact will not be gradual. It will be swift and brutal.

The real shock is coming. When companies invoke force majeure clauses, when construction projects stall, when visa renewals freeze, and recruitment stops, the impact will reach Kerala within weeks. If the conflict drags on, and all signs suggest it will, April and subsequent months will bring severe uncertainty. When that moment arrives, the illusion of *Kullu Thamam* will collapse. Kerala’s political leaders will realise too late that the State’s biggest economic crisis was unfolding in plain sight while they were busy with seat-sharing and personal attacks.

The Keralites in the Gulf are not just a diaspora to be celebrated at NRK events and airport welcomes. They are the backbone of Kerala’s economy. Their crisis is Kerala’s crisis. This election is the time to acknowledge that reality, before it is too late.

Rejimon Kuttappan is a labour migrant rights expert

Amid welfare pitch, Kerala ranks highest in most indicators

The growing economy has outperformed other States in social, educational, and health parameters

DATA POINT

Sambavi Parthasarathy
Nitika Francis

Kerala is set to hold its Legislative Assembly elections on April 9, and the results will be announced on May 3. The stage is set for a tight competition between the incumbent Left Democratic Front (LDF) and the United Democratic Front (UDF), with the NDA trying to make inroads into the State’s Assembly constituencies this year.

The three competing political fronts have released election manifestos which bet heavily on welfare via pensions. An analysis of key indicators shows that Kerala fares better than most in several indicators spanning health, economy, and education.

Table 1 shows Kerala’s ranking among other States in select economic indicators and its actual value as per the latest year. Kerala has demonstrated solid economic growth over the past decade, and ranked seventh among 23 States in per capita net State domestic product.

Data shows that economic development permeates Kerala’s rural population as well. The average daily wage rate in the State is ₹868, the highest among all States.

The State also ranks second among others in terms of Human Development Index (HDI), which takes health, education, and standard of living into account.

Table 2 shows Kerala’s rank across various health indicators. As per data from the National Family Health Survey for 2021-22, Kerala recorded an Infant Mortality Rate of 4.4, the lowest in India. The nationwide average was nearly eight times this figure, 35.2. Kerala also recorded the lowest Maternal Mortality Ratio in the country.

The State recorded low shares of women aged 15-19 who have begun childbearing. About 93% of surveyed women in Kerala also

have access to hygienic methods of menstrual protection. When it comes to children, only about 78% of Kerala’s child population have received all basic vaccinations, ranking 12th out of 29 States. However, it has the second-lowest share of children aged 0-5 years whose growth is stunted, closely following Sikkim.

Kerala is also a frontrunner when it comes to education-related indicators (**Table 3**). The State ranks among the top-performing States for the Adjusted Net Enrolment Rate (ANER) in elementary education (%). This indicator, as per the World Bank, refers to the number of pupils of the school-age group for primary education, enrolled either in primary or secondary education as a share of the total population in that age group.

Similarly, the State’s Gross enrolment ratio in higher secondary is higher than the all-India average of 57.6%. It is one of the top three States for this indicator. GER refers to total enrolment in a particular level of school education, regardless of age, as a share of the population of the official age group for a given level of school education.

With a ratio of 1.44, the State ranks first among 29 States on the Gender Parity Index in education (GPI). The indicator is the ratio of female to male students enrolled at a specific level of education.

The State is among the top-performing States for infrastructure indicators (**Table 4**). As per data, the share of urban households living in kachha houses in the State is null, less than the country’s average of 0.9%. It ranks second among 28 States with respect to Internet teledensity in rural areas.

But Kerala lagged a little behind on environment-related indicators. The State was among the top 10 States that generated high amounts of plastic waste per thousand population. It was also one of the top nine States in terms of per capita fossil fuel consumption.

(With inputs from Devyanshi Bihani)

Report card

The data for the tables were sourced from the National Family Health Survey (2021-22) and the NITI Aayog SDG India Index (2023-24)

TABLE 1: Kerala’s values and ranks in terms of Human Development Index and economic indicators

Indicator	Kerala’s value	Kerala’s rank	India average	Top States/U.T.s
Human Development Index (2023)	0.86	2 out of 29	0.732	Goa (0.862), Kerala (0.86), Delhi (0.837)
Per Capita net domestic product (₹)	3,08,338	7 out of 23	2,05,324	Delhi (4,93,024), Telangana (3,87,623), Karnataka (3,80,906)
Average daily wage rates in rural areas (₹)	868.7	1 out of 18	398	Kerala (868.7), T.N. (573.2), Himachal Pradesh (516)

TABLE 2: Kerala’s values and ranks across various indicators related to health

Indicator	Kerala’s value	Kerala’s rank (out of 29)	India average	Top States/U.T.s
Share of women aged 15-19 who have begun childbearing (%)	2.4%	1	6.8%	Uttarakhand (2.4%), Kerala (2.4%), Goa (2.7%)
Infant mortality rate	4.4	1	35.2	Kerala (4.4), Goa (5.6), Sikkim (11.2)
Share of population with unimproved sanitation facility (%)	0.2%	2	19.3%	Mizoram (0.1%), Kerala (0.2%), Sikkim (0.3%)
Share of children aged 0-5 years whose growth is stunted (%)	23%	2	36%	Sikkim (22%), Kerala (23%), Manipur (23%)
Share of children with all basic vaccinations	78%	12	77%	Odisha (91%), T.N. (89%), H.P. (89%)
Women using a hygienic method of menstrual protection (%)	93.3%	6	77.6%	T.N. (98.4%), Delhi (97.1%), Goa (96.8%)
Maternal Mortality Ratio (per 1,00,000 live births)	19	1	97	Kerala (19), Maharashtra (33), Telangana (43)
Households with at least one member covered by a health scheme (%)	57.8%	10	41%	Rajasthan (87.8%), A.P. (80.2%), Goa (73.1%)

TABLE 3: Kerala’s values and ranks across various indicators related to education

Indicator	Kerala’s value	Kerala’s rank (out of 29)	India average	Top States/U.T.s
Share of women (aged 15-49) who have done no schooling (%)	0.8%	1	22.6%	Kerala (0.8%), Mizoram (5.3%), Goa (5.5%)
Share of men (aged 15-49) who have done no schooling (%)	2.3%	1	10.7%	Kerala (2.3%), Goa (3.2%), Mizoram (3.4%),
Drop out rate (%)	5.5%	6	12.6%	Manipur (1.3), H.P. (1.5), T.N. (4.5)
Adjusted Net Enrolment Rate (ANER) in elementary education (%)	100%	1	96.5%	Multiple States (100%)
Gross Enrolment Ratio (GER) in higher secondary (%)	85%	3	57.6%	Delhi (94.9%), H.P. (94.1%), Kerala (85%)
Gender Parity Index (GPI) for higher education	1.44	1	N/A	Kerala (1.44), H.P. (1.33), Nagaland (1.28)

TABLE 4: Kerala’s values and ranks across various indicators related to environment and infrastructure

Indicator	Kerala’s value	Kerala’s rank	India average	Top States/U.T.s
Plastic waste generated per 1,000 population (tonnes/annum)	3.39	10 out of 23	3.04	Goa (18.93), Delhi (16.9), Telangana (12.57)
Per capita fossil fuel consumption (in kg.)	191.61	9 out of 21	166.43	Haryana (341.95), Gujarat (339.23), Himachal Pradesh (271.79)
Percentage of urban households living in kachha houses (%)	0%	1 out of 29	0.9%	Kerala (0%), Haryana (0.2%), Maharashtra (0.2%)
Internet subscribers per 100 population in rural areas	160.19	2 out of 28	38.33	Goa (174.98), Kerala (160.19), Sikkim (104.35)

FROM THE ARCHIVES

The Hindu.

FIFTY YEARS AGO APRIL 8, 1976

“City within city” in Government Estate

Madras, April 7: The Madras Metropolitan Development Authority is likely to take up special projects like development of a city centre in the Government Estate on Anna Salai and a commercial centre abutting the Quaide Millat College for women.

Draft proposals for these areas are ready and are being forwarded to the Tamil Nadu Government for its consideration.

It is proposed to develop the area inside Government Estate (27 hectares) in a big way as a shopping and office complex.

At present, this location is cluttered by miscellaneous uses and lends itself for redevelopment.

There will be business and commercial offices facing Anna Salai and Wallajah Road with a city centre complex built around Rajaji Hall and Kalavanar Arangam. Residential accommodation will also be provided to make this area a “city within a city”. Details are being worked out.

It is proposed to prohibit location of cinemas and other similar uses which generate peak pedestrian flows three or four times a day on the western side of the road. Since the city centre will be coming up, the planners feel that it is necessary to ensure a very high level of architectural standard. Not only the facade of the buildings require to be controlled but also the bulk and shape of the buildings in the area need to be regulated.

Being a shopping centre it is proposed to permit arcaded verandahs of approved design which would be three metres wide within the front area.

A HUNDRED YEARS AGO APRIL 8, 1926

Baron Rothschild fined

A special correspondent to “The Times of India” cables from Naples:—

Baron Maurice de Rothschild, it is stated, has been fined 370,000 lire (about £3,700) and Ettore Pisani and Alfredo Campanelli, two commission men, have been fined 120,000 lire (about £1,200) each for violating the law prohibiting the export of works of art without permission.

It is stated that in conjunction, they exported the famous statue “Mother of Venus.”

ASSEMBLY POLLS

Aboard a bus from Mumbai to Kerala for vote

▼ Kerala voters residing in Mumbai left for their home State on Tuesday to cast their vote for the Assembly election scheduled for Thursday.

Maharashtra Congress president Harshwardhan Sapkal, along with Amin Patel, MLA, flagged off the bus going to Kerala from Mumbai. “The elections are a celebration of

democracy, and it is the responsibility of all of us to take democracy forward. It is a good thing that those from Kerala who are in Mumbai for their livelihood are returning to their native places to exercise their voting rights,” Mr. Sapkal added.

Speaking on the coming Baramati Assembly byelection, the Congress leader termed as unnecessary the controversy surrounding his party's decision to field a candidate against Deputy Chief Minister Sunetra Pawar.



Maharashtra Congress chief Harshwardhan Sapkal flagged off the bus on Tuesday.

Assam tribal body calls for boycott of BJP

▼ Ahead of the election on April 9, a tribal organisation from Assam has urged indigenous communities to either boycott the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) or deny it their vote.

In a statement on April 6, the All Assam Sons of the Soil Indigenous Kochari Somaj accused the BJP-led State government of neglecting and

undermining tribal rights. It also said the government is trying to weaken their indigenous identity by placing six communities in a “protected class”.

Those communities are Adivasi (tea tribes), Chutia, Koch-Rajbongshi, Matak, Moran, and Tai-Ahom. The existing tribes want the government to guarantee that their rights and privileges would not be eroded before granting the Scheduled Tribe (ST) status to these six communities.



▼ The Congress fighting on its own in Bengal after 20 years is a booster dose... In 2006, we fought solo, in 2026, we are fighting on our own strength.
JAIRAM RAMESH
Congress leader

Mamata to file nomination in Bhabanipur

▼ West Bengal Chief Minister Mamata Banerjee's filing of nomination on Wednesday is being choreographed as a public assertion of Bhabanipur being a ‘mini India’, and West Bengal's pluralist identity. Ms. Banerjee wants her nomination to mirror the constituency's composite social character. PTI



▼ Mamata ji. I want to give you a suggestion. Do politics, but not politics of appeasement. Politics should be of satisfaction, not appeasement
RAJNATH SINGH
Union Minister and BJP leader



Assam Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma attends a poll rally in Jalukbari constituency. RITU RAJ KONWAR

Bid to win new voters in Assam CM Himanta's stronghold

Abdus Salam
GUWAHATI

A huge hoarding of ‘*Akou ebar BJP sorkar*’ (BJP government once more) greets visitors as they emerge from the Lokapriya Gopinath Bordoloi International Airport in Assam's Guwahati. However, there's little else giving away the fact that it's election season here barring an odd party flag or empty booth. The road to the city is festooned with more welcome messages, flags and posters for Prime Minister Narendra Modi and Home Minister Amit Shah during one of their numerous visits to inaugurate some project or lay the foundation stone for another – a hallmark of the BJP's signature style ‘permanent campaign’. There's a cartographic change, this time, though.

The airport area now marks the western limits of Legislative Assembly Constituency 37, Jalukbari, the seat that has sent Himanta Biswa Sarma to the Assam Assembly without fail since 2001. The 2023 delimitation exercise has left the Chief Minister with a newer set of voters to woo. Some regions from the erstwhile Guwahati West constituency have been incorporated, some ceded to adjoining Assembly segments.

Places such as Agyathuri, Mandakata, and Changsari on the north bank of the Brahmaputra in Guwahati are out; and areas such as Azara, Dharapur, and Garigaon, an old village of more than 14,000 residents, are in.

Mr. Sarma filed his nomination papers on the very first day, March 20, after a massive roadshow. “I first contested from Jalukbari in 1996 and lost. Since 2001, I have been winning continuously. Despite delimitation changes, I believe I will continue to receive the blessings of the people,” he said *en route*.

The Chief Minister is up against two other candidates, Bidisha Neog of the Congress and Dipika Das of the Bhumi Adhikar Party, contesting as an Independent.

Grooming Garigaon

Some locals are already sold on the idea of ‘Himanta Biswa Sarma, MLA, Jalukbari’, but the challenge for the BJP is to ensure healthy numbers in order to match or better the CM's six-figure margin from 2021. This is where Garigaon comes into play. Part of the peri-urban expansion of Guwahati, Garigaon and its fringes count caste Hindu Assamese and Bengali-origin Muslims among residents but it's *khilonjia* or *tholuwa* (‘indigenous’) Muslims who make up the majority.

“We are older than the Ahoms [who came to Assam in the medieval times and ruled for almost 600 years]. There's a mazar (shrine) of a Sufi saint in Garigaon that dates back to 700 A.D.,” claims Hukum Shan Ali Boxi, the local councillor who was aligned with the Assam Jatiya Parishad earlier but is now firmly with the ruling party.

The party machinery has been put to work, he says. Membership has swelled in recent months and the area is witness to daily door-to-door campaigns and corner meets ahead of polling day, April 9.

There are visible changes in Garigaon since the 2023 delimitation: paved roads with street lights lined alongside. “The local youth clubs, graveyard and madrasa have received funds too,” says Taher Ali, who runs a corner shop.

Iman Ali, in his seventies and a new member of the BJP Bishwabidyalaya Mandal Minority Morcha, concedes some old loyalists may still vote for the Congress.

IN FOCUS

B. Aravind Kumar
CHENNAI

It has been over two years since top Tamil actor Vijay launched his party, Tamilaga Vettri Kazhagam (TVK). Yet, with no electoral debut so far, there is little clarity on the party's potential vote share in the upcoming Tamil Nadu and Puducherry Assembly elections.

Within the party, optimism runs high, with some functionaries informally projecting a vote share of around 25%. Outside, however, estimates vary widely. A section of observers believes the TVK could mirror the early performance of the late Vijayakanth's DMDK, securing 8-10% in its first outing. Others suggest the party could push closer to 15%.

Predicting electoral outcomes in Tamil Nadu has never been straightforward, particularly in Assembly elections. The entry of TVK and of Mr. Vijay, a political greenhorn with Chief Ministerial ambitions, has only complicated the arithmetic further.

The party skipped the previous Lok Sabha polls, and the February 2025

Erode (East) Assembly by-poll. Consequently, its actual support base remains untested. The party's decision to go it alone has set the stage for a four-cornered contest in Tamil Nadu.

Was this strategic restraint – avoiding early electoral exposure – a deliberate move by Mr. Vijay to keep his political capital intact ahead of a high-stakes debut?

“Mr. Vijay knows what he is doing. Like in his movies, he is going by the script in politics as well,” said Professor G. Palanithurai, former Dean of Students' Welfare at Gandhigram Rural Institute.

Anti-corruption theme

There is a theory that Dravidian rhetoric has killed intellectualism in the State. Professor Palanithurai, who specialises in grassroots democracy, said he has been visiting campuses, and the lack of political discourse in higher education institutions has led to the youth gravitating towards the actor over time.

Besides, corruption has been regularised. The ruling DMK and Opposition AIADMK accuse each other of corruption but never take action against each other when in power.



Star-struck: TVK chief Vijay waves to supporters during a poll rally in Tiruchi. R. VENGADESH

“Mr. Vijay has sensed it. That is why he is focusing on an anti-corruption theme to attract voters. Vijayakanth also fought on the theme, but Mr. Vijay is more popular than Vijayakanth. He attracts huge crowds, especially youth. Even the ruling DMK can't bring in such crowds voluntarily,” he said.

While crediting the Dravidian parties with their development policies, both social and industrial, the academic, however, said politics had now become corrupt.

“Mr. Vijay is a film per-

sonality. He understands the psychology of the masses. The rule of law has now become the ruling party's law. That is why he is taking on the ruling governments,” he added.

“On the flip side, unlike [actor-turned-Chief Ministers] MGR and Jayalalithaa, Mr. Vijay is not close to the rank and file. He is in isolation all the time. Also, the TVK's second line of leadership is not impressive. However, Tamil Nadu's peculiar politics lacks a collective leadership as Dravidianism has shown the way to herding. Mass ap-

peal counts,” he asserted. Against the ideologically inclined DMK and politically masterful M. Karunanidhi, it was the personal charisma and political acumen of MGR and Jayalalithaa that had kept the AIADMK in power for a longer time than its arch-rival. Mr. Vijay seems to be gradually filling the charismatic leaders' role.

But is that adequate to penetrate the world of politics?

“Popularity in cinema doesn't always bring votes. We can't draw a parallel between Mr. Vijay and

MGR. The latter had a strong hold in the party, and he broke ranks while he was the treasurer of the DMK. He campaigned and worked hard for all those years. He also brought the underprivileged and the subaltern into his movies. The titles *Vivasayi*, *Padagotti* and *Meenava Namban* would resonate with communities,” said P. Ramajayam, an academic.

“Grassroots politics requires social and political mobilisation, involving several groups like minorities and subalterns”, he said.

Political observers feel that apart from the mass appeal, the party needs social and political mobilisation. The TVK should have a strength of 300 to 400 cadre per booth to secure around 100 votes each. If the party garners 15% of votes, Mr. Vijay would have a future as a politician.

“Mr. Vijay is certainly a large crowd puller, and the crowds are organic. Only two leaders do not pay for crowds— [Naam Tamilar Katchi's] Seeman and Mr. Vijay,” said R. Kannan, biographer of former Chief Ministers C.N. Annadurai and MGR.

Asked if Mr. Vijay would succeed, he says, “May 4 [election counting date] will give the answer.”

‘How can Bengal election be fair when so many genuine voters have been left out?’

Why did the BJP-led Centre have to go so deep to disenfranchise so many people if it is so confident of winning the State, asks the West Bengal Minister and three-time Trinamool MLA, who, like many other voters, has faced adjudication post SIR

INTERVIEW

Shashi Panja

Shrabana Chatterjee
Shiv Sahay Singh



when the Prime Minister was in the city.

You are a senior leader in the party and three-time MLA and Minister as well. What do you think of the 2026 election? And how do you think it is different from the 2021 election?

If the BJP, which says ‘*hum log aarahe hain*’ (we will come to power), is so confident of winning this election, then why did you actually have to do an SIR (special intensive revision)? You do a routine intensive revision like you did in Assam. Why did you have to go so deep to disenfranchise so many people? That means what you say and what you believe is so different. They put me, a three-time elected MLA,

under adjudication [after SIR citing discrepancies and cleared eventually] with what intent? I am a registered voter. Otherwise, why would I be elected or even stand for elections? If they could logically adjudicate me, just what have they done to others?

We can shout and scream, or we can go to court, but it takes time. *Di-di* [Chief Minister Mamata Banerjee] went to court over SIR. People are getting harassed. But still you're trying to cover up with a larger narrative to say, “*Muslims hain, ghuspetiya hain* (They are Muslims and infiltrators).”

If we take your constituency, Shyampukur, about 44,000 voters have been excluded, do you

think it is affecting the level playing field?

We all want free and fair elections. But where is fairness when you have got rid of so many legal voters? And regarding free elections, I mean, it's so unfortunate. They say we do Muslim appeasement. But during Ram Navami, we saw people armed with swords, and *Ram Ka Bhakti Geet* on DJ remixes. So, it is basically hyper-exhibitionism. The electorate here will not be like this.

Even if they delete voters, if they [BJP] can lose Ayodhya [in the 2024 Lok Sabha election], they can lose anywhere.

Your party has devised many women-centric schemes to cater to women voters. Can you elaborate on that?

Lakshmi Bhandar is a scheme with a financial incentive; it is hugely popular and has reached over 2.42 crore women. It's her money. It's her bank account. It's a single bank account, not a joint account with someone. It gives financial literacy and ‘*samman*’ (respect). Something that has been copied in

multiple other States, including the BJP-ruled ones.

One of BJP's campaigns is on the crimes against women in the State. With the party fielding the mother of the R.G. Kar victim, what kind of political messaging is it sending?

I was on the ground because R.G. Kar (Hospital and Medical College) is not very far away from where I stay and also not far from my constituency. I am an alumnus of R.G. Kar. So, I have seen those days and nights when there was spontaneous outpouring of grief and sympathy for the victim (referring to the doctor who was raped and murdered in 2024.)

We also faced criticism. We had condemned the incident. Who would want such a thing to happen? We have nothing to say on the mother of the victim deciding to step into politics on BJP ticket. It's her choice. Even when the incident happened, we did not evade our responsibilities. Kolkata Police arrested the culprit. The CBI could not unearth anything more. (Full interview at newsth.live/WBpolls)

Elect BJP for a ‘Sonar Bengal’, says Bihar leader

Amit Bhelari
PATNA

Bihar Deputy Chief Minister, Samrat Choudhary, on Tuesday urged the people of West Bengal to extend their support to the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) to transform the State back into a ‘*Sonar Bengal*’.

Mr. Choudhary asserted that the BJP was committed to expelling the infiltrators, establishing democracy and restoring Bengali identity and pride.

Mr. Choudhary was in Howrah to attend the nomination filing of several candidates contesting the West Bengal Assembly election.

“Just as West Bengal played the most pivotal role in the struggle for independence, Bengali society is now ready to rise and overthrow the Mamata [Banerjee] government – a regime characterised by its support for infiltrators, anti-Hindu stance, and anarchic governance,” Mr. Choudhary said.

Mr. Choudhary pledged that just as the Bihar government had provided government jobs and employment opportunities to five million people over the past five years, similar large-scale job creation initiatives would be undertaken in West Bengal as well.

Fast breeder nuclear reactor at Kalpakkam takes ‘critical’ leap forward

Jacob Koshy
NEW DELHI

Marking a significant step forward in India's nuclear power programme, Prime Minister Narendra Modi, via a post on social media platform X late on Monday said that the prototype fast breeder reactor (PFBR) at Kalpakkam, Chennai, had achieved “criticality”. This means that the nuclear reaction in the reactor had become safely self-sustaining, and was on its way to being able to produce electricity.

“Today India takes a defining step in its civil nuclear journey advancing the second stage of its nuclear programme...the PFBR at Kalpakkam has attained criticality...it is a decisive step towards harnessing our vast thorium reserves,” Mr. Modi posted.

While it will be some months before the PFBR is powered up to its full capacity, and even longer before it produces useful electricity, multiple experiments have to be conducted at low power to check if it's running as expected, which must be evaluated by the Atomic Energy Regulatory Board before it grants a go-ahead for commercial power operation, this the beginning of the second stage of India's nuclear programme.

Since it was first formally approved as a project by the government in 2003, the PFBR at Kalpakkam has taken over two decades to reach this stage.

PFBR as a bridge
India's nuclear reactors are heavily dependent on imported uranium. The country's three-stage programme, conceived in the

1950s, envisages being able to be independent of imported uranium, creating its own stockpile of suitable uranium, and eventually harnessing thorium, of which it has vast stores. The PFBR development serves as an essential bridge.

“This is a historic moment,” Anil Kakodkar, Member, Atomic Energy Commission and former head of the Department of Atomic Energy, told *The Hindu*, adding, “What this means is that we are now on our way to extract 80-100 times more energy from a given quantity of uranium.”

The PFBR is a 500 MW sodium-cooled, pool-type fast breeder reactor designed by the Indira Gandhi Centre for Atomic Research and built by Bharatiya Nabhikiya Vidyut Nigam Limited, both operating under the Department of Atomic Energy.

Uranium powerhouse
India's pressurised heavy water reactors (PHWR) burn up uranium to produce electricity and small quantities of plutonium. However, less than 1% of the energy from this uranium (that can be used as heat and make electricity)



Prime Minister Narendra Modi witnesses initiation of core loading of indigenous prototype fast breeder reactor at Kalpakkam. PTI

ger using fresh, mined uranium here. As a thumb rule, this means that the 1% energy extracted can go up to nearly 10% for a single cycle and for every additional cycle 10% more. The efficiency of the uranium that is mined goes up substantially, Ravi Grover, Member, Atomic Energy Commission, told *The Hindu*.

“The burn-up or the energy extracted goes from about 8,000 units (in a PHWR) to nearly 100,000 units,” Mr. Grover said.

Two more reactors
India's current plan, Mr. Grover said, was to construct two more PFBR at Kalpakkam, though this would only be following a proper assessment of the performance of the PFBR for a year. In the current scheme of things, the PFBR

will produce only “marginally more” plutonium.

“Our current priority is to use the uranium that we have far more efficiently. There is a reprocessing plant to come up on site at Kalpakkam which will use the processed spent fuel from the PFBR and for the two future PFBR. The PFBR will use depleted uranium (from the Pressurised Heavy Water Reactors or PHWRs).

In the future, we will use thorium, but that is still a long time away, and what kind of reactors we will use for that, we need more work and have to wait and watch,” he said, adding, “These reactors are self-sustaining but as and when we need more plutonium in the future, the design has to be optimised to extract more plutonium.”

Currently, India has a fleet of 18-20 PHWRs that

use natural uranium as fuel and produce plutonium-239 (Pu-239) as a by-product in spent fuel. India's full fleet of 23 nuclear reactors have a combined capacity of 7.48 GW. India hopes to have 100 GW by 2047 and this is premised on a larger fleet of Bharat Small Modular Reactors (which are scaled down PHWR) that are in the pipeline.

A significant technological challenge that has led to delays in the PFBR is the use of liquid sodium as a coolant to manage the extremely high heat from fissioning uranium atoms in the PFBR. In India's current reactors, the heat is largely absorbed by ‘heavy water’, or in some cases, ordinary water. Once fully operational, the PFBR is expected to generate 500 MW of electricity, with a design life of 40 years.

INBRIEF



5-kg LPG quota doubled amid Hormuz tensions

The government has doubled the daily quota of market-priced 5-kg LPG cylinders for migrant workers as part of a broader push to stabilise fuel supplies amid disruptions linked to tensions around the Strait of Hormuz. Unlike the subsidised 14.2-kg cylinders that are used in household kitchens for cooking, the 5-kg bottles are priced at market rates. A 5-kg cylinder costs ₹549 in Delhi as against the ₹913 price for a 14.2-kg domestic cylinder. The 5-kg cylinders are available across-the-counter at LPG distributorships on production of an identity card. With the war in West Asia disrupting energy supplies, the government has prioritised gas to households as the cost of commercial users, who were initially given only 20% of their requirement and in steps raised to 70%.

Govt. extends halt on TV news TRP by four more weeks

The Information and Broadcasting Ministry has extended the suspension of Television Rating Point (TRP) reporting for TV news channels by four more weeks, or until further directions. The Ministry of Information and Broadcasting on March 6 asked the Broadcast Audience Research Council to suspend the publication of TRP ratings for news channels. The order had previously been issued for four weeks, or until further directions, in view of the “unwarranted sensationalism” surrounding coverage of the war between the United States, Israel, and Iran. The policy guidelines says, “The company shall be required to comply with any orders etc., issued by the Ministry from time to time.”

NCERT reconstitutes textbook committee after top court rap

Michel Danino, former guest professor at IIT-Gandhinagar, among three dropped; IIT-Madras Director, ex-NLSIU V-C part of 20-member team

Maitri Porecha
NEW DELHI

The National Syllabus and Teaching Learning Material Committee (NSTC), which overlooks the formulation of new textbooks, has been reconstituted by the National Council of Educational Research and Training (NCERT), following the Supreme Court's intervention on a section of “corruption in the judiciary” in the now-discontinued Class 8 social science textbook.

In an April 2 notification, accessed by *The Hindu*, the NCERT stated that it had reconstituted the 22-member high power committee, which now includes IIT-Madras Director V. Kamakoti; Indian Council of Historical Research (ICHR) Chairman Raghuendra Tanwar; R. Venkata Rao, former Vice-Chancellor of the National Law School of India University (NLSIU); and Amarendra Prasad Behera, Joint Director-in-Charge, Central Institute of Educational Technology, NCERT. The committee now consists of 20 members

Three members – Michel Danino, former guest



Michel Danino

Professor at IIT-Gandhinagar; M.D. Srinivas, Chairman of the Centre for Policy Studies, Chennai; and the late Bibek Debroy, former Chairman of the Prime Minister's Economic Advisory Council (EAC) – have been removed from the NSTC.

Mr. Danino's removal from the NSTC comes after the top court's order stating that the Centre, States, Union Territories, universities, and public institutions should dissociate themselves from three members of the textbook development team who drafted the Class 8 social science textbook chapter under question.

Mr. Danino, in an affidavit filed in the court on April 4, said that the implication by the NCERT that the chapter was drafted exclusively by three indi-

viduals alone (including Mr. Danino) gave an inaccurate picture and that the textbook was the result of a “collective and collaborative” process. “A Google group with over 40 members was established early on, as a well-oiled mechanism to overcome geographical constraints and regularly share and discuss drafts across Curricular Area Group - Social Science members and others. This group was used to share successive versions of the chapter the Judiciary on 01.09.2025, 23.10.2025, 04.11.2025 and 03.12.2025,” Mr. Danino stated in his affidavit.

The NCERT has retained former National Institute of Educational Planning and Administration Chancellor M.C. Pant as the Chairperson, along with Princeton University maths Professor Manjul Bhargava as the co-Chairperson in the reconstituted NSTC. The other 14 members of the old committee, including Infosys Foundation chairperson Sudha Murty; singer Shankar Mahadevan; Chamu Krishna Shastry, chairman, Bharatiya Bhasha Samiti; EAC-PM member Sanjeev Sanyal, have been retained.



Bangladesh Foreign Minister Khalilur Rahman, left, being welcomed upon his arrival in Delhi on Tuesday. ANI

Bangladesh Foreign Minister arrives in Delhi, meets Doval

Kallol Bhattacharjee
NEW DELHI

Bangladesh Foreign Minister Khalilur Rahman arrived here on Tuesday. This is the first high-level bilateral visit from Bangladesh in more than a year, although Mr. Rahman, who was National Security Adviser in the interim government of that country, had travelled to Delhi in November 2025 for a regional meeting.

Mr. Rahman met National Security Adviser Ajit Doval for dinner on Tuesday in a start to his official interactions.

During his stay here, from April 7 to 9, Mr. Rahman is expected to hold several other meetings with top officials of the Indian government, including his counterpart, Union External Affairs Minister S. Jaishankar.

“India and Bangladesh

share warm and historic ties anchored in strong people-to-people relations. The visit will further bolster India-Bangladesh partnership,” Randhir Jaiswal, spokesperson of the External Affairs Ministry, said, welcoming Mr. Rahman, who is accompanied by Humayun Kobir, Foreign Affairs Adviser to Bangladesh Prime Minister Tarique Rahman.

Mr. Rahman and Mr. Kobir were received by B. Shyam, Joint Secretary of the External Affairs Ministry's Bangladesh-Myanmar division, and the High Commissioner of Bangladesh, Riaz Hamidullah.

A lunch meeting will be hosted for Mr. Rahman at Hyderabad House on Wednesday by Mr. Jaishankar.

Mr. Rahman will also meet Commerce Minister Piyush Goyal and Petroleum Minister Hardeep Singh Puri.

‘Records on caste census decision can’t be disclosed’

Abhinav Lakshman
NEW DELHI

The Union government has stated that records of the Inter-Ministerial deliberations, inputs, and suggestions referred to in making the decision to enumerate caste in the 2027 Census are exempt from public disclosure under the Right to Information Act, 2005.

Responding to a request for these records filed by *The Hindu* under the RTI Act, the Union Cabinet Secretariat said that these records were exempt from disclosure under Section 8(1)(i) of the 2005 law. This section says the government is not obligated to disclose Cabinet papers, provided that “the matter is over” or “complete”; and provided that “the decisions of Council of Ministers, the reasons thereof, and the material on the basis of which the decisions were taken shall be made public after the decision has been taken”.

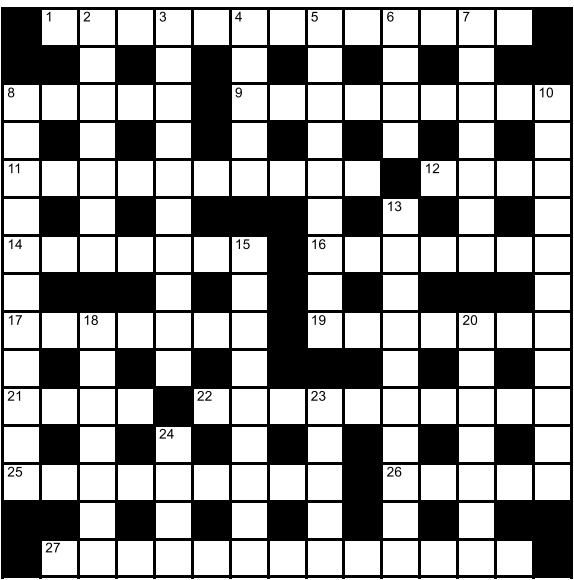
On April 30, the Centre posted a statement, saying, “Cabinet Committee on Political Affairs has decided to include caste enumeration in the upcoming Census.” On March 25, responding to requests for information on records relied upon for this decision, the Cabinet Secretariat said, “The information sought is exempted from disclosure under Section 8(1)(i) of the RTI Act.”

**THE HINDU****CROSSWORD****+****14762**

(set by Dr. X)

Solve this puzzle online and access more puzzles at <https://thehindu.com/crosswords>





Across

1 Pen pal is upset about American leader's bluntness (5,8)
8 Calls topless escorts (5)
9 Miss Japan picked up by champion in American club (9)
11 Old-fashioned person, one giving spinal anaesthesia? (4,6)
12 Expert checking teen's latest skin condition (4)
14 Unknown tramp in base beginning to eat mushroom (7)

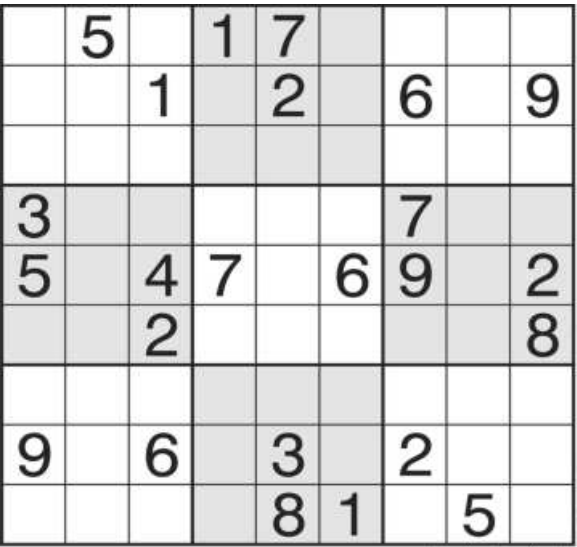
Down

16 Emblem over sides of simple historical torch (7)
17 Write about old jerk showing favouritism (7)
19 Holy place in Muscat renovated around end of Ramadan (7)
21 Mongrel beginning to bite, getting muzzle (4)
22 Guests on island primarily getting loose motion (10)
25 Researcher analysed onset of cancer in testis (9)
26 American associate touring most prosperous city in Chile (5)
27 Raged at elderly doc outside hospital in a callous manner (4-9)

Down

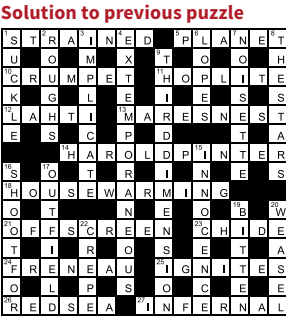
2 Fancy place has new, special camera accessory (4,3)
3 Complete details of a nudist streaking at opening on ground (3,3,4)
4 Oily secretion from small whitehead essentially on butt (5)
5 Disappears from scene, vigorously cutting guard in retreat (9)
6 Khaka, Kane welcoming former Brazilian footballer (4)
7 Suggestions by star about tackling bad acne (7)
8 Turns head to stare as masseur kisses amorously (11)
10 Urge to steal opal, take money in jars (11)
13 Serves gin cocktail, hosting a preview of art exhibition (10)
15 Old cryptic clue is very elegant (9)
18 Colonnade in dock essentially built by company (7)
20 Minor in contest, having endless energy (7)
23 Reptile in bog at Oregon (5)
24 Set up banquet in American city (4)

SUDOKU

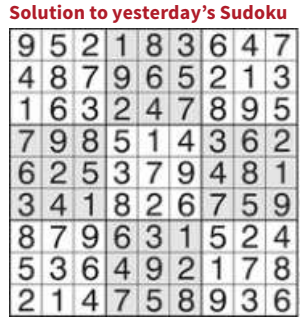


DIFFICULTY RATING: ★★★★★

Solution to previous puzzle



Solution to yesterday's Sudoku



FAITH

Revered saint Nammazhvar

There lived in Thirukkurugur a ruler named Kari. His wife Udayanangai was from the sacred town of Thiruvananthapuram, a town near Nagercoil. The pious couple were sorrowful, because they had no children. They worshipped Lord Nambi of Thirukkurugudi, praying for progeny. The Lord told them that He Himself would be born as their son, said V.S. Karunakarachariar in a discourse. Soon, Udayanangai became pregnant. The son who was born to her was the avatara of Viswakshena, and was the revered saint Nammazhvar. Nammazhvar was born in the star of Visakha in the month of Vaikasi. A gas known as *satam* is supposed to cloud one's intelligence at birth. Nammazhvar conquered this *satam*, and hence is called Satakopa.

But Nammazhvar was unlike other babies, for he did not drink milk. He didn't seem to feel hungry. He did not cry either. The worried parents took the child to the shrine of Adinatha Perumal of Thirukkurugur. They laid the baby at the feet of Lord Adinatha. To the astonishment of everyone, Nammazhvar got up and did a circumambulation of the temple. In the *prakara*, there was a tamarind tree, with a hollow. The infant jumped into the hollow and remained there. He did not respond when people spoke to him. He still continued to do without food and meditated. It was to this place that Madhurakavi Azhvar came later, looking for a guru. Madhurakavi posed a philosophical question to Nammazhvar. The latter's reply convinced Madhurakavi that Nammazhvar was the guru he was looking for. Nammazhvar wrote four works: Thiruvirutham, Thiruvasiriyam, Peria Thiruvandadi and Thiruvaimozhi. His four works give us the essence of the four Vedas.



A CH-CHE

DEEP TECH SUMMIT



Latest tech: A race car with advanced technology on display at the summit. B. VELANKANNI RAJ



Question time: Participants interacting with a panellist at the summit in Chennai on Tuesday. B. VELANKANNI RAJ



Snapshot moment: Visitors taking a photo at the Deep Tech Summit. B. VELANKANNI RAJ



Immersive experience: Students visiting the expo stall at the summit. B. VELANKANNI RAJ

Leaders weigh in on why Indian healthcare cannot function in silos



(From left) Puhazhendi Kaliyappan, Medical Devices Consultant and Adviser; Dr. Vishal Gandhi, Founder and CEO, BIO, Rx, Chief Investment Officer - Indian Healthcare Angels; Aravind Ganesan, CTO, Kauvery Hospital; Senthil Kumar Rajendran, Investor, Partner, Mentor and Adviser and Koushik Ramani, Managing Partner and Co-Founder, NetworkGain Consulting. B. VELANKANNI RAJ

The Hindu Bureau CHENNAI

At *The Hindu* Deep Tech Summit 2026 on Tuesday, a quiet but decisive shift in thinking took centre stage – the end of silos in healthcare cannot afford to be theoretical, it has to be operational. At the panel on ‘Convergence of Disciplines: End of Traditional Engineering Silos’, moderated by Koushik Ramani, managing partner and co-founder, NetworkGain Consulting, voices from medicine, technology, and venture capital converged to outline what the future of healthcare must look like – integrated, adaptive, and deeply human.

For Puhazhendi Kaliyappan, a leading medical devices consultant and adviser, the transformation is already under way. The traditional pillars of healthcare – pharma, in-vitro diagnostics, and medical devices – are dissolving into one another. Technologies once treated as stand-alone products are now components feeding into larger, AI-driven systems focused on outcomes. “Everything is becoming outcome-driven,” he said, pointing to shifts, including home-based care, community-level screening, and even emerging diagnostics based on smell. The question, he argued, is no longer about devices, but infrastructure – how do we build healthcare into everyday spaces like homes and apartments?

‘Uniquely complex’

From the hospital floor, Aravind Ganesan, chief technology officer of Kauvery Hospital, grounded this vision in reality. “It’s actually nonsensical to build in silos in healthcare,” he said, emphasising that systems designed without doctors or patients in mind inevitably fail. Healthcare, he noted, is uniquely complex – serving both doctor and patient as “a unit of one”. Without integrating clinical workflows and addressing workforce shortages, even the most advanced technologies risk irrelevance.

For Vishal Gandhi, founder and CEO, BIO Rx and

Experts speak on what the future of healthcare must look like – integrated, adaptive, and human

chief investment officer at the Indian Healthcare Angels, convergence is not new – it is foundational. Trained in biotechnology, he described a discipline inherently built at the intersection of physics, chemistry, and biology. What has changed, he said, is scale and speed. With AI entering drug discovery, the industry is beginning to de-risk a historically high-failure process. From reducing dependence on animal trials to enabling precision medicine and surgery, “You are the real doctor,” Dr. Gandhi said, pointing toward a future of real time, personalised healthcare powered by data.

Need for coordination

Yet, technology alone cannot guarantee impact. Senthil Kumar Rajendran, investor, partner, mentor and adviser, warned that without coordination, even the most sophisticated systems collapse into irrelevance. As AI blurs boundaries, value lies not in isolated innovation but in connected ecosystems. “If your systems are not built to solve coordination, the purpose itself goes for a toss,” he said, adding that healthcare remains a “black horse” – not just financially, but in its potential to transform lives.

That transformation is already reshaping care delivery. Hospitals, Mr. Ganesan said, may soon evolve into distributed care networks, with routine monitoring shifting to homes through wearables and connected devices. What we call healthcare today, Mr. Rajendran added, has largely been “sick care” – reactive rather than preventive. The next decade could reverse that.

Underlying it all was a simple but powerful reminder – healthcare is not a hardware problem, or a software problem; it is a human problem. And human problems, by nature, refuse to stay in silos.

More than 70% of the funding for R&D comes from government, says panel

Experts from government, academia, venture capital firms say private sector’s limited stake reveals both caution and a systemic gap; they add that for early-stage start-ups, the pathway is clearer than before, but not necessarily easier, and caution against losing originality in race to follow trends

Siddhi Nawar CHENNAI

Commencing conversations on day two of *The Hindu* Deep Tech Summit 2026 on Tuesday, a familiar question took on a new urgency: who carries the risk of innovation in India, and who should? At the panel, “The State as a De-risker: Aligning Academic Excellence with National Strategic Mission”, voices from government, academia and venture capital firms converged to confront diverging issues. The session was moderated by N. Nagaraj, Vice-President of Digital Media at *The Hindu*.

At the heart of the conversation was a striking imbalance. “More than 70% of R&D funding comes from the government,” noted Ramanan Ramanathan, Chairperson of the National Expert Advisory Council on Technology, Innovation and Incubation, Department of Science and



Leading voices: (From left) Vibha Malhotra Sawhney, Head, Technology Management Directorate and Innovation Protection Unit, CSIR; Sridhar Bharathwaj, Founder, Exponential Integration VC Pvt Ltd; Ramanan Ramanathan, Chairperson - National Expert Advisory Council on Technology, Innovation and Incubation of Department of Science and Technology; Rishi Dewan, Associate, StartUp India; Ashwin Mahalingam, co-founder, Okapi Research Advisory and Professor, IIT-Madras; and N. Nagaraj, Vice-President, Digital Media, *The Hindu*. S.R. RAGHUNATHAN

Technology, calling it a “sad fact”. For a country aspiring to lead in deep-tech, the private sector’s limited stake reveals both caution and a systemic gap.

Yet, the state is stepping in decisively. Sridhar Bharathwaj, founder, Exponential Integration VC Pvt. Ltd, pointed out that the

government is now absorbing early-stage technological risk – Technology Readiness Levels (TRL) 1 to 3 – validating ideas before they reach the market. But the real gap, he argued, lies beyond validation, where founders must translate research into business. Innovation alone is not enough; founders must

think in terms of value, returns and scale.

For early-stage start-ups, the pathway is clearer than before, but not necessarily easier. Rishi Dewan, Associate at Startup India, emphasised that the first step is often recognition – formal acknowledgement that unlocks funding, mentorship and infrastructure.

SRM will set up tech, research park by 2027: Shantanu Sudhakar Patil

The Hindu Bureau CHENNAI

Students from Tier-2 and Tier-3 cities are quite keen on start-ups, but many are constrained either by limited access to funding or geographical barriers, according to Shantanu Sudhakar Patil, an orthopaedic physician and director of entrepreneurship and innovation at the SRM Institute of Science and Technology. In order to bridge this gap, SRMIST has established a rural-tech incubator at its agricultural campus, he said.

He was speaking at *The Hindu* Deep Tech Summit on Tuesday, in a fireside chat with R. Kalpana Sastry, a scientist, agri-food innovation consultant, and executive director of the Society for Technology Management (STEM), on



Shantanu Sudhakar Patil, Director, entrepreneurship & innovation, SRMIST, and R. Kalpana Sastry, Scientist, Agri-Food Innovation Consultant, Executive Director, STEM on Tuesday. S.R. RAGHUNATHAN

the topic of ‘Leveraging a multi-disciplinary university ecosystem for enabling the deep-tech revolution’.

‘Open to ideas’

“We are open to anyone who approaches us with an innovative idea, strong team and adequately developed business plan, who

doesn’t have to be a faculty member or a final year student.. Apart from this, we are encouraging students from all colleges, including students from schools, to build start-ups,” said Dr. Patil. “We have also introduced design thinking for faculty, so that they can identify the problem first

before looking for a solution,” he added.

Citing data on research and development investments in India, Dr. Sastry said that though there is a lot of research with potential to be converted into spin-offs, there are very few university-led spin-offs across the country. To address this concern, Dr. Patil said that access to the right technological ecosystem is critical. “Learning from what IIT Madras Research Park has done, we are also replicating an SRM Technology and Research Park which will be up and running by the end of 2027,” he added.

One of the university’s priorities is women-led initiatives in entrepreneurship. “About six of our start-ups in BioNEST are women-led, which is a start,” he said.

Several start-ups got expression of interest after pitches: Ananth Kumar

The Hindu Bureau CHENNAI

Curtains came down on *The Hindu* Deep Tech Summit 2026, held in collaboration with SRM Institute of Science and Technology (SRMIST), after two days of insightful discussions and exchanges on emerging trends in the deep-tech space.

The event brought together industry leaders, innovators, and academics to explore the future of cut-



Curtain call: Ananth Kumar, Associate Director DEI, SRMIST offering the vote of thanks on Tuesday. B. VELANKANNI RAJ

ting-edge technologies. Thanking *The Hindu* for curating this summit, Ananth Kumar, Associate

Director, Directorate of Entrepreneurship and Innovation (DEI), SRMIST, pointed out that apart

from institutions like IIT-Madras Research Park, private universities are also contributing towards deep-tech.

He also mentioned that boardroom pitches were done with firms which are in pre-revenue, revenue stage and those looking for capital for scaling their ventures. “We had a panel of investors who thoroughly analysed each of the pitches. And five out of ten start-ups have got expression of interest,” he added.

Innovation is the buzzword at Deep Tech Summit 2026



Talent on display: Team Rudra from SRMIST displays its Mars rover at the summit. S.R. RAGHUNATHAN

The Hindu Bureau CHENNAI

From agriculture to healthcare, aspiring entrepreneurs on Tuesday showcased innovations at *The Hindu* Deep Tech Summit 2026, reflecting a growing ambition to enter the entrepreneurship ecosystem. At his stall, Gokula Kannan K., co-founder and director of Valyria Visions Private Limited, said, “Our start-up through its platform Phenolens focuses on solving a very fundamental but ignored problem in India’s ₹25 lakh crore crop credit system – banks are lending without actually knowing what is happening on the ground.”

“Today, loan approvals depend on field visits, paper records, and assumptions. Phenolens replaces this with satellite-based intelligence that verifies land boundaries, confirms whether crops actually exist, measures acreage, and generates a risk score within two to three minutes, even before a loan is disbursed. It also continues

monitoring crops after disbursal, helping banks act before defaults happen,” he added.

Surender Sundaram’s Propel Tech Innovations, incubated a year ago, focuses on the “testing and development of advanced defence technologies, with focus on material science, aerospace, and robotics.” The start-up is trying to address the defence sector’s reliance on procuring components from other countries.

Tamirabot, founded by its director Velayutham S., develops and manufactures next-generation electric vehicle charging connectors for fast-charging application. “We have our patented technology for boosting the charging efficiency by 7.8% by reducing the thermal rate build-up within the connectors that causes energy loss and lifetime of the connector,” he said. Team Rudra from SRMIST displayed its rover at the summit. The team builds Mars rover prototypes from the scratch every year.

JERUSALEM
Completed forward deployment in south Lebanon, says Israel military



AFP
The Israeli military said on Tuesday it had completed the deployment of ground troops along a “defence line” in southern Lebanon, where it is fighting Iran-backed Hezbollah. A Lebanese military source said the Israeli army had advanced to a depth of between five and nine km inside Lebanese territory. AFP

KYIV
Russian air strikes on Ukraine’s southeast kill seven, hit city bus



REUTERS
Russian attacks on two cities in Ukraine’s southeast on Tuesday killed seven persons and injured at least 16, officials said, with Kyiv accusing Moscow of escalating strikes. A small FPV Russian drone smashed into a bus in Nikopol’s city centre, governor of the eastern Dnipropetrovsk region, said on the Telegram app. REUTERS

DHAKA
Hasina-era Parliament Speaker Shirin arrested in Bangladesh



AFP
The Bangladeshi police arrested the former Parliament Speaker on Tuesday on attempted murder charges, marking the first detention of a prominent figure from Sheikh Hasina’s toppled government under the newly elected one. Shirin Sharmin Chaudhury, the South Asian nation’s first female Speaker, also served as a Minister. AFP

UNITED NATIONS
Russia, China veto UN resolution on reopening Strait of Hormuz



REUTERS
Russia and China vetoed a UN Security Council resolution on Tuesday on reopening the Strait of Hormuz, a text already diluted to remove Gulf states’ desired green light to use force to protect the key shipping lane. The draft resolution prepared by Bahrain received 11 votes in favour, two against and two abstentions. AFP

Iranians form human chains at power plants after Trump threat

State media claims ‘more than 14 million people registered’ to join after a campaign online and through SMS texts; people reportedly stand around key energy sites, bridges in Bushehr, Tabriz, Mashhad, Ahvaz; hashtag *janfada* trending in Iran

Agence France-Presse
TEHRAN

Iranians formed human chains to protect power plants on Tuesday after U.S. President Donald Trump’s threats to strike energy infrastructure, according to images published by state media, as top officials said they were also prepared to sacrifice their lives.

After a campaign online and through SMS texts to sign up for the human chains nationwide, officials claimed that more than 14 million people had joined.

It was not immediately possible to verify that figure or how many people were taking part, although initial images showed do-



Broken dreams: Iranians rally during a memorial for those killed in Minab school strike, in Tehran on Tuesday. AFP

zens involved at each location.

The state-run IRNA news agency showed people forming a human chain “to support power plants” in the southern city of Bushehr, which is home to

Iran’s nuclear power plant. State television and the Mehr news agency showed dozens of people outside the main power station in the northern city of Tabriz, as well as at a plant in the northeastern city of Mash-

had. With U.S.-Israeli strikes also targeting bridges, people gathered on the main span over a river in the western city of Ahvaz, Mehr reported.

While the more than five-week war between the Islamic republic and the United States and Israel has seen a whole echelon of the Iranian leadership killed, strikes on energy plants would mark a major escalation.

Iran Parliament Speaker Mohammad Bagher Ghalibaf, seen by some as the country’s de-facto number one after the killing of Supreme Leader Ali Khamenei at the start of the war, published a screenshot of what was purportedly the registration system for the

human chains.

Saying he had registered his own name, he added: “Mohammad Bagher Ghalibaf is ready to sacrifice his life for Iran.”

The Persian word for self-sacrifice – *janfada* – became a trending hashtag on social media.

“More than 14 million proud Iranians have so far registered to sacrifice their lives to defend Iran. I too have been, am, and will remain ready to give my life for Iran,” President Masoud Pezeshkian wrote on X on Tuesday.

Mr. Trump earlier warned “a whole civilisation will die” in Iran if the country did not heed his midnight deadline to open the Strait of Hormuz.

Gun battle near Istanbul’s Israeli consulate; one dead

Reuters
ISTANBUL

One attacker was killed and two others were wounded in an extended gun battle with police outside the building housing the Israeli consulate in Istanbul on Tuesday, according to authorities.

Police officers pulled out guns and took cover as shots rang out for at least 10 minutes near a permanent security checkpoint. One person was seen covered in blood amid the glass towers in the heart of the city’s main financial district.

Footage obtained by Reuters showed an apparent attacker, in a dark top and carrying a backpack, moving among parked white police and security buses and firing, with an automatic rifle and a handgun.



Police officials gather outside the Israeli Consulate in Istanbul following a shootout between gunmen and police on Tuesday. AFP

Two bodies lay on nearby streets and parking areas, near grassy areas.

The three attackers had links to an organisation that “exploits religion”, Interior Minister Mustafa Ciftci said, adding that two of them were brothers.

Two police officers were lightly wounded in the attack, Istanbul Governor Davut Gul told presspersons at the scene. He said

there had been no Israeli diplomatic staff at the consulate for two and a half years, since the Hamas-Israel war began in 2023, leading to a deep chill in Turkish-Israeli diplomatic ties.

The incident occurred next to a major motorway just after midday, immediately outside the tower where the Israeli consulate is located.

Suffocating times



Strong dissent: Autorickshaw drivers hold Pakistan’s national flag and shout slogans during an anti-government protest in Lahore on Tuesday against rising fuel prices triggered by the West Asia war. AFP

Sri Lanka rolls out ‘relief package’ to help citizens amid West Asian crisis

Meera Srinivasan
COLOMBO

Sri Lanka on Tuesday rolled out relief measures to help citizens cope with the impact of war in West Asia.

Addressing Parliament, President Anura Kumara Dissanayake announced fuel and fertilizer subsidies, and a temporary increase in the government’s targeted cash transfer programme for the poor. Further, the government will bear the cost of electricity for consumers using less than 90 units over the next three months. “The total relief package is valued at 100 billion rupees (roughly \$317 million) over three months,” he said, adding that the “relief pack-



age” was being funded through the existing Budget.

Mr. Dissanayake’s announcement comes a week before Sri Lankans mark the Sinhala and Tamil New Year, one of the biggest festivals celebrated on the island. It also coincides with the government’s ongoing talks with a visiting delegation of the International

Monetary Fund (IMF). A staff-level agreement for the next tranche of the Fund’s \$2.9 billion-assistance to Sri Lanka – extended following the 2022 economic crash – is expected this week. Meanwhile, ordinary citizens, already grappling with IMF-linked austerity, are now forced to contend with sharp hikes in fuel, LPG, and electricity prices.

Amid the persisting uncertainty in fuel supplies and global oil prices, Sri Lanka is in talks with Russia and China to augment supplies in the coming months. On March 28, India delivered 38,000 metric tonnes (MT) of petroleum to Sri Lanka, including 20,000 MT of diesel and 18,000 MT of

petrol, following a telephone call between President Dissanayake and Prime Minister Narendra Modi. A top official at the state-run Ceylon Petroleum Corporation (CPC) said the country’s current fuel stocks will ensure smooth supply until end of May. “We have been talking to Russia, and we are now in discussion with China, to augment supply going forward,” Mayura Neththikumarage, Managing Director of CPC, told The Hindu. “The QR-code system introduced last month to manage supplies has helped us,” he added. Sources at Lanka IOC, the second largest supplier on the island, said it had stocks to last until mid-May.

Kuwait issues advisory, asks residents to stay in

Agence France-Presse
KUWAIT CITY/MANAMA

Kuwait asked residents to avoid going outside from midnight until Wednesday morning, hours ahead of a U.S. deadline for Iran to agree to a deal or suffer major strikes on civilian infrastructure.

“The Interior Ministry tells citizens and residents that it is crucial to stay at home and avoid going out, unless absolutely urgent,” a statement said.

Bahrain’s main port, Khalifa Bin Salman, will suspend operations starting early Wednesday.

A Lebanese seafarer caught in a double-whammy amid war

M. Kalyanaraman

For Akkad Soubhi, the West Asia war has been what the Americans would call a double-whammy. Chief engineer on a car carrier ship anchored off Khor Fakkan, Mr. Akkad has been caught in the middle of the West Asia war. His family in Lebanon too wakes up to missiles and bombs every day. Fearful of a civil war breaking out, they are planning to move to Turkey or Syria.

Mr. Akkad has been stuck in his ship carrying more than 1,000 cars for over a month – off Fujairah first, now off Khor Fakkan. His ship was about to enter the Strait of Hormuz on March 2 when they got the message that Jebel Ali port,

their destination, had been attacked. And they decided to stay near Fujairah.

Unlike other seafarers, Mr. Akkad’s home country is also in distress. Though he says that he lives in Sunni-dominated north Lebanon that often escapes Israeli attacks, he fears a civil war may break out once again in the country.

He cites the recent killing of a Christian leader by drones looking for a Hezbollah operative in central Lebanon.

“Christians are now angry at Shias and may turn against them and refugees,” he says, recalling the devastating civil war of the 1980s.

“Every 10 years, there is a big conflict. We are used to that. But this time may

be different. It’s all push-button now and war is easy to do.”

He says the second officer on his ship is from South Lebanon. “His house was completely destroyed recently. I tried to console him that at least his family was safe,” he says.

Seeking sanctuary

Mr. Akkad says his mother will be moving to Türkiye soon. And his wife and daughter will move there after a month once his daughter’s university education is over.

“We are considering moving to Syria. Though there are low-intensity troubles there, the country is relatively more peaceful than Lebanon,” he adds.

In the Gulf of Oman,



Stuck in limbo: Cargo ships in the Gulf, near the Strait of Hormuz, as seen from northern Ras al-Khaimah. REUTERS

too, it has been a daily dance of death. Mr. Akkad talks of missiles hitting another ship just one nautical mile away and destroying it. He saw the Fujairah port attacked and one large fuel tank hit. “We saw the blaze for nearly a

week.” Hundreds of merchant ships are stuck in the Gulf unable to move up or down the Strait of Hormuz. Nearly 30,000 seafarers are estimated to be on-board these ships. Long anchorages often mean ship crew doing major

maintenance work on equipment. But this is war. The ship needs to be always ready to move, which means all the equipment are ready for operation.

On March 21, for instance, the owners asked them to move to Khor Fakkan port for discharging. After 100 cars rolled out, suddenly, the harbour master came to them and said there was information that the port was going to be attacked and ships had to leave. Since then, Mr. Akkad’s ship has been anchored off Khor Fakkan port.

Typically, ships make fresh water on board using water used to cool the engines. When a ship is not sailing, there is no source of hot water from the en-

gine and no water can be made. But ships are being supplied water and food supplies by owners.

“We have told our crew that if they want to leave, repatriation can be arranged. But we are all staying,” he says proudly, pointing out that his ship has 19 Indians out of a total of 24 crew. They all have Internet and are talking to their families. “We even had a near miss when a missile that seemed to be coming at us was intercepted.”

Humour often helps alleviate the tension on board. A form of gallows humour, almost. “We have learned to shout hello to the drones. They fly so close that they can hear us if they have ears,” he says.

A recognition for emerging Tamil Nadu sportspersons

Ten young athletes from the State receive ₹50,000 each in the annual event organised by CSK and TNSJA; Mhatre, the India u-19 World Cup-winning captain, is the chief guest



Chess wizards: Tamizh Amudhan and Aaranya receive the scholarships from Rupa Gurunath and Ayush Mhatre. R. RAGU



Glowing with pride: Paddler Shriya Anand is handed her prize by table tennis ace Sharath Kamal, right, and Bhagwandas Rao. R. RAGU



In the limelight: Dharshini gets her scholarship from Srinivasa Raj and Sandhiya. R. RAGU



Reward: Baskaran and Viswanathan give away the scholarships to Shashaank and Dharanidharan. R. RAGU

Sports Bureau CHENNAI

Ten budding sportspersons were presented with ₹50,000 each at the Chennai Super Kings-Tamil Nadu Sports Journalists' Association Scholarships 2025-26 held with the support of the Tamil Nadu Cricket Association at the M.A. Chidambaram Stadium on Tuesday.

Chess prodigies – the eight-year-old Tamizh Amudhan (the only under-9 player in the world rated above 2000 Elo) and nine-year-old R. Aaranya (Asian youth champion) – were the youngest beneficiaries this year.

Among those present were CSK's Whole-Time Director Rupa Gurunath, CEO K.S. Viswanathan, India under-19 World Cup-winning captain and CSK batter Ayush Mhatre, Olympic gold medal-winning hockey skipper V. Baskaran, and table tennis legend A. Sharath Kamal.

The other prominent sportspersons were veteran volleyball player M. Utkrapandian, former India U-19 cricket captain M.

The TNSJA scholarship winners (₹50,000 each)

Tamizh Amudhan (chess), R. Aaranya (chess), Shashaank Saravanakumar (para cycling), T. Dharanidharan (javelin throw), S. Dharshini (football), Shriya Anand (table tennis), D. Sowmiya (volleyball), P. Harish (surfing), S. Asrankha (cricket) and B.K. Kishore (cricket)

Senthilnathan, former TN cricketer S. Sharath (BCCI junior selection committee chairman), and India footballer R. Sandhiya.

TNCA president T.J. Srinivasa Raj, secretary U. Bhagwandas Rao and Dr. R.N. Baba were also in attendance.

Hailing the TNSJA's efforts, Rupa promised to continue CSK's support for talented sportspersons.

"It's an honour to carry forward my father N. Srinivasan's legacy. He has always supported all sports, not just cricket.

"I liked what was said earlier that this should not be your (athletes') destination, but a sign that you are on the right path. It's humbling to be here and share the stage with these young athletes. I'm happy to be part of this and to continue



Proud parent: Sugandhi, surfer Harish's mother, receives the scholarship from Dr. Baba and Jayaveena. R. RAGU



Rewarding excellence: Srinivasa Raj and Senthilnathan make it a day to cherish for Asrankha. R. RAGU



Picture perfect: Sowmiya receives the scholarship from Sharath Kamal and Utkrapandian. R. RAGU



One for the album: Mohammed Riaz and Sharath present the scholarship to Kishore. R. RAGU



supporting the association," she said.

Viswanathan said: "We are contributing to a cause that is good for all sports. CSK is a franchise that doesn't focus only on cricket. It's a tradition set by N. Srinivasan, and we are following it."

Mhatre wished the award recipients the very best. "I also began my cricketing journey at a young age. I can understand how this scholarship can motivate [the young sportspersons]. I appreciate TNSJA for doing this. All the best to the youngsters," he said.

Baskaran was also full of praise, but he had a request: "Appreciate TNSJA for wonderfully selecting these champions. I put my heart into it, and I ask you to make it much bigger. I wish every athlete a wonderful journey in the near future."

Sharath Kamal urged the young awardees to aim higher. "Firstly, it's a fantastic event, getting to meet our fellow superstars in various sports and, at the same time, the young, talented crop of athletes. It's a great job, TNSJA.

Jadeja's seven-wicket haul, including a hat-trick, dismantles Sea Hawks



SPORTS BUREAU CHENNAI

Singam Puli's left-arm spinner Dharmendra Jadeja returned figures of seven for 35, including a hat-trick, to dismantle Sea Hawks for just 101 in its first innings on the first day of a 10th-round match in the TNCA first division at SSN College ground, here on Tuesday.

In response, skipper U. Mukilesh's composed 51 helped his side gain a 21-run first-innings lead with three wickets in hand.

At IITM-Chemplast, Alwarpet left-arm spinner P. Vidyuth claimed six for 39 as Jupiter CC was skittled out for 83. In reply, Alwar-

pet was bowled out for 128 as it earned a valuable 45-run lead, despite off-spinner Subhan Krishnan Sridhar's spell of five for 47.

At Wahe Guru-A, Nelson's left-arm spinner R. Nishaanth 51, S. Swaminathan 30, V. Maaruthi Raghav 50 n.o., R.D. Pranav Ragavendra 4/51, R. Srinivasan 3/51 vs Globe Trotters 59/0 in 16 overs (D. Santhosh Kumar 40 batting).

Toss: Trotters.

At Guru Nanak: MRC-A 218/5 in 90 overs (N.S. Chaturved 34, Kiran Karthikeyan 30, M. Boopathi Vaishna Kumar 42, B. Anirudh Sitaram 55 batting) vs Vijay.

Toss: MRC-A.

At SRMC: Jolly Rovers 265/7 in 90 overs (R. Vimal Khumar 70, B. Sachin 43, C. Andre Siddharth 39, B. Indrajith 40, R. Bharat Srinivas 4/80, S. Mohan Prasath 3/51) vs Young Stars. **Toss:** Young Stars.

At Wahe Guru-A: Grand Slam 104 in 45.5 overs (Vignesh S. Iyer 33, R. Sanjay Yadav 5/25, A. Esakkimuthu 3/38) vs Nelson 174/2 in 42 overs (Shivam Singh 33, Shoaib Mohd. Khan 60 batting, T. Saran 42, S. Rithik Easwaran 30 batting).

Toss: Nelson.

TNCA LEAGUE

Massive wins for Gandhi Nagar Starlets and Madras Indians

T. Adhavan's 177 and B. Arun Kumar's six for 62 powered Gandhi Nagar Starlets to a 203-run win over IAF (Tambaram) in a TNCA V-B match recently.

S. Kavirama Prajapathi's 120 and skipper V. Karthikeyan's 116 propelled Madras Indians to a 233-run win over YMCC.



Top performers: Adhavan (Gandhi Nagar Starlets, 177); Prajapathi (Madras Indians, 120); Prithivraj (ICI S & RC, 102); Saurabh (Gopalapuram, 102); Arun (Gandhi Nagar Starlets, 6/62); Richhpal, (IAF (Tbm), 5/63); Karthikeyan (Madras Indians, 116).

Abhijith 36). ICI 254 in 49.4 overs (S. Prithivraj 102, M. Muthu Jeeva 39, C. Venkatachalam 52) bt Egmore Excelsiors 235 in 48 overs (P. Hariharan 97, S. Arunkumar 78, M. Arul 3/56).

Madras Indians 404/3 in 50 overs (S. Kavirama Prajapathi 120, V. Karthikeyan 116, M. Sudarsan 67, Ansh Adiga 60 n.o.) bt YMCC 171 in 35.5 overs (Vinay M. Davey 37 n.o., A. Krish Vikram 4/39).

Netaji 276/8 in 50 overs (C. Andrew Wesley 49, T. Hari

Vignesh 51, B. Dhushyanth 39, N. Ajay Sachin 36 n.o., Pradesh 4/62) bt Gopalapuram 274/9 in 50 overs (S. Saurabh Kumar 102, P. Balaji 40, M. Vignesh 34, J. Gokul 4/54, S. Vetrivel 3/69).

Gems 222 in 50 overs (R. Dhanush

Adit 42, B. Esanth Mugil 57, P. Herbert George 40, S. Madhavan 4/47, K. Lalit 4/57) lost to Madras University Union 226/6 in 47.5 overs (S. Shrinand 48, K. Lalit 64, S. Muhammad Shahid 45 n.o., R. Lovanish 3/64).

ENGAGEMENTS

Cricket: TNCA first division league, day two, Alwarpet vs Jupiter (IITM-Chemplast), Sea Hawks vs Singam Puli (SSN), Globe Trotters vs SKM (MRF-Pa-

chaiyappa's), Vijay vs MRC-A (Guru Nanak), Young Stars vs Jolly Rovers (SRMC, turf), Nelson vs Grand Slam (Wahe Guru-A), 9.30 a.m.

ALL INDIA INSTITUTE OF MEDICAL SCIENCES
EXAMINATION SECTION

ADMISSION NOTICE NO. 41/2026

F.No.AIIMS/7-10/Exam.Sec/(B.Sc-M.Sc-2026)/2026

24-03-2026

Admission Notice for B.Sc. (Hons.) Nursing/B.Sc. Nursing (Post-Basic)/B.Sc. Allied & Health care courses and M.Sc. Nursing/M.Sc. courses/M.Biotechnology for session August-2026 at AIIMS New Delhi & other AIIMS

All India Institute of Medical Sciences, New Delhi invites Online applications for Entrance Examinations leading to admission for subject cited above courses in below mentioned schedule.

SCHEDULE FOR UNDER-GRADUATE COURSES	
Commencement of Online Registration for submission of application for B.Sc. (Hons.) Nursing/B.Sc. Nursing (Post-Basic) B.Sc. Allied & Health Care Courses August-2026 session	Start Date: 25-03-2026 Closing Date: 24-04-2026 (05.00 PM)
Date of B.Sc. (Hons.) Nursing Examination	27 th June, 2026 (Saturday)
Date of B.Sc. Allied & Health Care Courses Examination	04 th July, 2026 (Saturday)
Date of B.Sc. Nursing (Post-Basic) Examination	30 th May, 2026 (Saturday)

SCHEDULE FOR POST-GRADUATE COURSES	
Commencement of Online Registration for submission of application for M.Sc. Nursing/M.Sc. courses/M. Biotechnology August-2026 session	Start Date: 25-03-2026 Closing Date: 24-04-2026 (05.00 PM)
Date of M.Sc. Nursing Examination	20 th June, 2026 (Saturday)
Date of M.Sc. Courses/M. Biotechnology Examination	13 th June, 2026 (Saturday)

All applicants are required to visit the website www.aiimsexams.ac.in regularly since all subsequent Corrigendum/ Addendum/Updates will only be uploaded on the website.

CBC 17112/12/0003/2627

ASSISTANT CONTROLLER (EXAMS.)

Uttar Pradesh Medical Supplies Corporation Limited

(CIN: U85310UP2018SGC102425) (A Government of Uttar Pradesh Undertaking)

Address: SUDA Bhawan, 7/23, Sector-7, Gomati Nagar Extension, Lucknow

Advertisement No:- UPMSCL/04/HR/2026-27/28

Dated: 06/04/2026

Uttar Pradesh Medical Supplies Corporation Limited invites application for the following position on Deputation/ Contractual:

Sr. No.	Designation	Maximum Age Limit (In year)	Vacancy	Category	Mode of Recruitment	Honoraria in INR (Monthly)	Essential Qualification	Desirable Qualification	Post Qualification experience
1	Bio Medical Engineer (Quality Control)	45	01	UR	Deputation/ Contractual	(47,600-50,000) Pay Matrix -8 (in case of Deputation)	Applicant must have full time Bio Medical Engineer Degree (B.E./B.Tech) from recognized Indian University	Certificate/ Diploma in Quality Control/ Management	Applicant must have minimum 3 year's work experience in the field of Bio Medical Engineering Quality
2	Account Officer	45	01	UR	Deputation/ Contractual	(47,600-50,000) Pay Matrix -8 (in case of Deputation)	Applicant must be CA (Inter)/ ICWA(Inter) or M.Com	MBA (Finance)	Applicant must have minimum 3 year's work experience in Finance & Accounting
3	Pharmacist (Quality Control)	45	01	UR	Deputation/ Contractual	(47,600-50,000) Pay Matrix -8 (in case of Deputation)	Applicant must have B.Pharm degree or graduate in Science (Chemistry/Bio-Chemistry) discipline from a recognized University/institution		Applicant must have minimum 02 year's of experience in the field of Drug Quality Control

* Interested Candidates must send their application form in the prescribed format along with self attested relevant document by speed post/registered AD from Indian Postal Department by mentioning on the envelop " Application for the (Post Name)" to I/C GM (AHL), SUDA Bhawan 7/23 sector -7 Gomi nagar extension, Lucknow PIN-226010. Applications sent by any other mode shall not be entertained. Submission of Application Starts from April 06, 2026. * The Last Date of Submission of Application is May 05, 2026 at 06:00 PM.* Regular government (Department/Corporations/Institutions) employees with suitable experience on seniority (matrix level) are encouraged to apply on deputation. * Vacancies shall be subject to the State reservation policy of Uttar Pradesh. * Age relaxation shall be provided as per the State reservation policy. Candidate applying on Deputation shall be in accordance with Govt. of UP Service Norms. * Please note that last date of application form shall be taken as a reference date for computing age, qualification, experience etc. Application not received on prescribed format will be rejected. Application format may be download from the website:- www.upmsc.in

For vacancy notification and other related detailed information please visit www.upmsc.in

Department of Medical Health & Family Welfare, Uttar Pradesh

CORRIGENDUM FOR TENDER
NOTICE NO.: CON/2026/MAR/01
DATED: 03-03-2026

Corrigendum No. 01 & 02 for Tender Notice No. CON/2026/MAR/01, dated: 03-03-2026 against Tender No. CE-CON-DESIGN-GC-2026-01 has been published. For details please visit in website www.ireps.gov.in.
Chief Engineer/Con/ Design, Maligaon
NORTHEAST FRONTIER RAILWAY
Construction Organization
Serving Customers With A Smile

EAST CENTRAL RAILWAY

OPEN E-TENDER NOTICE

Tender Notice No.TC-31-2026-SPJ.

The Divisional Railway Manager (Engg)/ E.C.Railway/Samastipur for and on behalf of the President of India invites Open Tender from experienced and financially capable tenderers for the following works in E-tendering mode of IREPS web portal of Indian Railways:- 1. Name of work: (i) DBG-SMI Section - Through channel sleeper renewal (H-beam) with chequered plate on various girder bridges (Br. No. 18) Total- 155 Nos. (ii) MFP-SMI: TBSR (H-beam) with chequered plate on various girder bridges (Br. No. 59, 60, 61, 63 & 67) Total- 562 Nos. 2. Tender Value: Rs. 24268814.92/- 3. Earnest Money: Rs. 485300.00/- 4. Completion period of the work : 09 Months. 5. Last Date & time for receiving of Tender in E-Tender mode on IREPS web portal :-27.04.2026 upto 12.00 hours. 6. Opening Date & time for E-Tender:27.04.2026 after 12.00 hours. 7. Website particulars where complete details of tender & tender document can be seen on Website: www.ireps.gov.in. Amendments/modifications if any shall not be published in the newspapers but the same shall be uploaded in the website.
S.C. Divisional Engineer/Cord
E.C.Railway/Samastipur
PR/0029/SPJ/ENGG/7/26-27/40

EAST CENTRAL RAILWAY

OPEN E-TENDER NOTICE

NOTICE NO. S&T/SEE/E-O7/26-27/01.

The DRM (Sig. & Telecom)/SEE for and on behalf of the President of India invites Open E-Tenders for the following works. The last date of online E-tendering is 28.04.2026 up to 12.00 hrs. All information and tender documents related to E-tender is available on website - www.ireps.gov.in E-Tender No.S&T/SEE/E-O7/26-27/01. 1. Name of Work : Strengthening of signalling arrangements/infrastructures for dual detection using MSDAC in parallel to DC track circuit at LAK & BGS. 2. Approx Cost: Rs.3,73,12,060.17/- 3. Earnest Money : Rs. 7,46,300.00 -/- 4. Cost of Tender Document (In Rs.) (Non-refundable): 0.00/- 5. Completion period: 09 (Nine) Month from date of issue of LOA . The above tender notice is available on website www.ireps.gov.in. Uploading date 02.04.2026. RIGHT OF RAILWAY TO DEAL WITH TENDER : Railway Administration reserves the right to postpone/modify or to cancel any one or all the tenders without assigning any reasons.
Divisional Signal & Telecom Engineer
E.C. Railway Sonpur
PR/0030/SEE/S&T/26-27/40

INTERVIEW

Heinrich Klaasen

Anirudh Velamuri
HYDERABAD

Heinrich Klaasen entered this season of the Indian Premier League carrying a few lingering self-doubts. The South African has been away from the intensity and grind of international cricket for nearly a year, a gap that can unsettle even the most seasoned players in a format as unforgiving as T20.

Determined to stay competitive, Klaasen explored new ways to keep himself in rhythm. If the first three matches are any indication, those efforts are paying off handsomely. With 145 runs at a strike rate of 147.95, including two half-centuries, the Sunrisers Hyderabad star has not only found his groove but shifted the pressure firmly onto the opposition – and then some.

In an online interaction, Klaasen reflected on his form and that of his team, his dominance against spin, his electric partnership with Nitish Kumar, and more. Excerpts:

Starting the IPL with back-to-back 50s must feel good...

Unfortunately we've lost two games, but on a personal note, it's been a good start. One of my biggest concerns was not playing as much cricket as I used to. Can I still keep up with the standard that I set myself with? It's been a pretty good start and hopefully this form will continue.

How have you adapted to stepping away from international cricket?

International cricket is a big miss in my game, but there are small things that I do that just keep me up to the pace of normal cricket speed. I've been working with a lady in Cape Town called Sherryll, who's an eye doctor. We call it an EyeGym. It just helps you make a lot of decisions under pressure and in a certain amount of time. That has been working for me over the last year in making sure that my decision-making and reaction times are good.

It's just that one percent that you have to take a little bit more care of and give yourself a little bit more training right before coming into a competition like this. Normally, you can have a week or two off before you come into a long tournament like this. I just had to change my training schedules and make small tweaks like that to make sure that I get up to speed as quickly as I can.

How would you assess Sunrisers Hyderabad's performances so far?

It's a tough question. I will give us about a six at this moment.

We have played some brilliant cricket in parts, but we're just losing the plot in the crucial phases of the game. We lose it so badly that it just puts us out of the game entirely.

If you take the game against Royal Challengers Bengaluru, we lost three wickets in the PowerPlay. Same against Lucknow Super Giants.

I honestly do think the bowlers are hanging on exactly as planned. That aspect is doing very well. The rest of the batting unit is doing well. There are a lot of positives. I'll say about 80% positive.

Our fielding in the first two games hasn't been up to standard at all. In our last game, against LSG, it was better. We're working on that, and we're setting a new standard for ourselves to put teams under pressure and make sure we hang on to our catches. But it's not at the standard that we set for ourselves, as it stands.

I'll give us a six and not go with seven, which is an easy cop out. We want to get to eight and nine to make sure that we get some momentum. There's no panic in the changing room yet. We're looking forward to getting on a roll and putting all three compartments of the game together.

SRH's batting line-up is probably the most fearsome in the league. But with Pat Cummins missing, there are some concerns over the bite in the bowling unit, at least on paper. What do you make of it?

Our batting has been good so far, but we've missed out on about 40 runs over the three games. So there's still a lot of work to do for our batters.

Obviously, if you miss a bowler like Pat Cummins, it's a loss for any team in any format. Same with (Brydon) Carse. The rest of the bowlers are super experienced, especially our pace department.

The wickets have been good in the two games in which we struggled in. We just didn't execute with the bat like we wanted. It's easy to say our bowlers don't have the experience or are under the pump, but in the two games that we've lost, the batters left about 20 to 30 runs on the board.



K.R. DEEPAK

We saw it against KKR, we put enough runs on the board... That's our job. We need to get to that 220-230 mark. That's why we have set up the team we have now, so we give our bowlers a proper chance at defending.

SRH's spin pool looks relatively inexperienced with players like Harsh Dubey and Shivang Kumar. What have you made of their ability to work under pressure? Is that lack of experience really such a big factor, especially in the middle overs?

They've been fantastic so far. Our poor fielding makes their figures look bad. Our fielding has been poor against them, so that makes their figures look bad.

The team should take it on the chin and keep encouraging them (Harsh and Shivang) to do what they do.

Having faced them in the nets, I can tell you that they may be inexperienced on paper, but they're definitely experienced in playing the game and know what to do with the plan.

They bowl extremely well. They haven't really played on wickets that've been spinning too much. They're just hanging on at the moment, picking up



We're getting everything together and, hopefully, we can make it to the IPL playoffs. We will have an extremely good chance of winning the trophy then

crucial wickets when we need it. I can't wait till we get to a wicket that just suits them a little bit more, and then people will see the brilliant skill set that they have.

What do you make of Ishan Kishan the captain so far?

He's been superb so far. He's a guy who asks for advice. We've got a lot of experience in the changing room, so he leans on that as well. But his decision-making, the way he changes the ball, the way the team listens to him, has been phenomenal so far.

We're in superb hands and luckily, he's not an arrogant guy at all, which makes it a lot easier. He's a really enjoyable captain to play under.

There are a lot of jokes in between which helps because this game brings

quite a tough environment to play in.

He's been superb and he has had some success in the domestic scene as well. I think his domestic team won a competition recently, so there's a lot of experience in that aspect.

TravisShek's wonderful starts – how much of a cushion does that give the team?

It depends on how you see it. Sometimes, when they go at 14 or 15 an over, you feel like the wicket is extremely flat or they make it look flat and you want to keep up with that pace. Sometimes that can put you under pressure a bit.

But having played with them for three seasons now, I do understand that you can play on tempo as well. They give you the luxury to hold on and get yourself in and then go again so that the run rate never really drops below 11 or 12.

How has your role in this side evolved?

It's a role that I've played my whole life and in my whole career. You have to adapt to those situations and you have to be able to play different roles in the team. My role in the team is to keep on going if TravisShek and Ishan have put

the opposition under pressure.

But the days that doesn't happen, I need to make sure we get into a position to defend a total.

I know that's my role. I have to play four or five different ways, but that's just what is required to be a professional cricketer at this moment. Every game is going to present different situations. It takes a different set of skills to understand those things and execute plans accordingly.

You have a great partnership going with Nitish Kumar. How are you both finding a rhythm in the middle-order?

It helps when you play together for a couple of years. You start to understand each other, you understand what makes each other tick. Our communication this season has been incredible. We've been taking a lot of pressure off each other, especially from his side.

He's been taking a lot of pressure off me at the start of my innings. So a lot of credit needs to go to Nitish.

He's in form at the moment, so that makes it a lot easier as well to drop and change our plans as we go and to identify the bowlers each of us likes to take down.

He reminds me of playing with David Miller. In your career, you get a few guys you just enjoy batting with.

Nitish is extremely quick so when you feel like you're under pressure a bit, you can always run two or three and make the over a little easier instead of just searching for boundaries.

Running between the wickets becomes a crucial part of the game then. I love seeing him grow as well. It's just been fantastic this season and hopefully we can put on a couple of more big partnerships.

You have been known as the spin destroyer of SRH. How did that come about for you?

South Africa has some quality spinners and I've played a lot of four-day cricket at a stage where my career really needed it. It is a stage where probably all of those spinners played four-day cricket as well.

I'm used to the ball turning away from me. I faced a lot of Tabraiz Shamsi in the nets, who is a quality spinner as well.

A lot of training, a lot of hours have been spent experimenting. I've been in India for five to six years now. Over the years, I've gained some experience.

Earlier in my career, we went to Sri Lanka, where the ball actually spun quite a bit. We had to figure things out for ourselves and learn new tricks.

I'm very blessed to be able to play spin well. It's always a challenge to keep taking them on because I know they're looking to get my wicket.

Is it safe to say that you love playing in India against the spinners specifically?

The boundaries here are not the biggest in the world. We're used to some big boundaries. But the wickets are fantastic, so it's a nice place to come to. It's still a big challenge. I know they're coming for me and they know I'm coming for them.

This season, I see that they've got a couple of game plans, so I need to get back to doing some good homework against them and finding new ways of scoring against them.

Is there any Indian spinner that you enjoy playing against the most?

It's an easy answer, Yuzi (Yuzvendra) Chahal. We've had a few great battles over the last couple of years. He's a quality bowler and very clever.

I think we're about 50-50 on winning those battles. He's a good mate of mine as well, which makes it even better to fight against him on the pitch.

Does the IPL stand out in any way compared to the other leagues?

It's by far the toughest there is in franchise cricket. I sometimes feel it's tougher than international cricket. It depends on who you play but the standard of cricket and obviously the conditions play a big part.

Every year, you just see a new Indian player coming through who you never knew about.

The talent just sets the standard so high. It is by far the best competition in the world. There are a couple of tournaments they are striving to reach the same standard. But it's tough.

Do you have a message for the Sunrisers Hyderabad faithful?

Just be patient. You can't win a competition in the first week. We're getting everything together and, hopefully, we can make it to the IPL playoffs. We will have an extremely good chance of winning the trophy then.

I think we're long due and we've got the squad to win a trophy. Keep supporting us and we're looking forward to producing some good performances.

Making sense of the science in *Project Hail Mary* and its alien world

The film does a good job of reminding us that space is cool and science is Amaze! Amaze! Amaze!

Rudraa Abirami Sudarshan

Extra-terrestrials have always been a fascinating subject for us humans. In the media, they have been portrayed from comically homicidal Martians in *Mars Attacks* to stoic Spock in *Star Trek* and the curious and childlike E.T. The latest to join the ranks of the non-earthling denizens of the universe is Rocky, the adorable rock-like Eridian from *Project Hail Mary*.

Rocky is unlike the humanoid lifeforms we have come across. He has five limbs, no face, no eyes, he uses echolocation to ‘see’, and speaks with musical chords. His ‘skin’ has a rock-like texture but is not rock. His species is far more intelligent than ours, with photographic memory and processing power surpassing human limitations, and is infinitely more empathetic. He’s bound to make you go “Amaze! Amaze! Amaze!” – a refrain in the film – but where could Rocky have come from and is there a chance he could exist in real life?

A special star

In the film, Rocky hails from the star system 40 Eridani. To visit him with our current technology is impossible.

Even if you manage to cobble together a working starship, the star his planet orbits, 40 Eridani A, is 16.34 light years away, making a one way trip more than 2,80,000 years long if you travel at 17 kilometres per second.

But if you do visit Rocky, you could meet Spock as well: Vulcan also orbits 40 Eridani A.

What makes this star so special that we have not one but two alien species originating from there?

One of the main factors scientists look for when searching for potential extra-terrestrial life is a habitable zone: a band of space around a star where the conditions are just right for a planet to have liquid water on the surface, allowing life (as we know it) to evolve.

40 Eridani A does have a habitable zone 101.7 million km from it. Scientists had also glimpsed some evidence that there could be a planet orbiting the star but they haven’t been able to confirm it exists. The same ‘evidence’ can also be explained by variations in the star’s light output.

But if this planet exists, it also needs to have certain favourable conditions of its own to support life.

Life on Erid

From the information available on Rocky’s home planet, dubbed Erid, it would be eight-times heavier than the



Ryland Grace (Ryan Gosling) works with the alien ‘Rocky’ in a scene from ‘Project Hail Mary’. AMAZON MGM STUDIOS/YOUTUBE

earth and orbit 40 Eridani A once every 42 days. If it is also as dense as the earth, Erid could be a rocky planet with gravity twice as strong as our own. However, Erid would also be only 33 million km from 40 Eridani A, and its surface would be too hot to sustain liquid water: it would boil off.

The only way to circumvent this problem would be if the planet had a high atmospheric pressure, which in turn would increase the boiling point of water, and a strong magnetic field.

Since Erid is too close to its star, the chances are that its atmosphere will be blown away by stellar winds from 40 Eridani A unless it has a dense atmosphere like Venus.

Venus’s atmosphere is made of carbon dioxide and nitrogen blanketed by clouds of sulphuric acid. This creates a strong greenhouse effect that increases the planet’s temperature and pressure.

For Erid, author Andy Weir – whose book the film is based on – decided that the atmosphere would be composed of ammonia and that the planet would have a very strong magnetic field.

Senses for Eridians

Thus, Rocky and his compatriots would have an environment suitable for living, albeit a very hot (210 degree Celsius) and high-pressure one.

The star 40 Eridani A does have a habitable zone 101.7 million km from it. Scientists had also glimpsed some evidence that there could be a planet orbiting the star but they haven’t been able to confirm it exists.

This is also why it is a miracle that Dr. Ryland Grace (Ryan Gosling) isn’t instantly killed when Rocky breaks out of his enclosure to save him. The enclosure has conditions preserving those on Erid, for Rocky’s sake, but between the high pressure ammonia gas and the heat flooding into the cockpit, Dr. Grace’s lungs should have been destroyed. In the book, however, Rocky uses the airlock.

With such a thick atmosphere, Erid will also have low visibility, which is why Rocky’s ship is so dark: he doesn’t need ‘eyes’ to function. Eridians would then have to have evolved other senses to get around.

One of them is echolocation (like bats on the earth); another is that their rocky skin can ‘hear’ the vibrations that bounce off it.

The film also depicts an idyllic beach on Erid. It may not be a real beach so much as a specialised and

temperature-controlled biosphere with perfect earth-like conditions inside.

Eating stars

Rocky isn’t the only alien in the film. The Astrophage, who is the film’s main antagonist, is also an extra-terrestrial lifeform. The Astrophage is like algae, except that it grows on the surface of stars instead of in the ocean. It is also a very efficient source of fuel.

But on the flip side, its energy consumption levels are so high that it is capable of draining our own sun, taking our world right back to the ice age.

But the Astrophage is also not very scientifically sound: it is able to store energy only because of a made-up phenomenon called “super-cross-sectionality”.

Technically, us earthlings are also only one or two very-efficient fuel sources away from building our very own Starship Enterprise.

In the end, *Project Hail Mary* is still fictitious and requires more than a little suspension of disbelief to make certain things work. Nonetheless the film does a good job of reminding us that space is cool and science is amaze! Amaze! Amaze!

(Rudraa Abirami Sudarshan is an astrophysicist, science communicator, and journalist. rudraasudarshan@gmail.com)

THE GIST

For the alien’s planet, dubbed Erid, author Andy Weir decided that the atmosphere would be composed of ammonia and that the planet would have a very strong magnetic field

Rocky and his compatriots would have an environment suitable for living, albeit a very hot (210 °C) and high-pressure one

This is also why it is a miracle that Dr. Ryland Grace (Ryan Gosling) is not instantly killed when Rocky breaks out of his enclosure to save him

BIG SHOT



A member of Saudi Arabia’s state-run Saudi Falcons Club holds saker falcons before their release into the wild as part of a population restoration programme together with Kazakh partners, at Altyn-Emel National Park, Kazakhstan on March 29. REUTERS

QUESTION CORNER

Energy from space



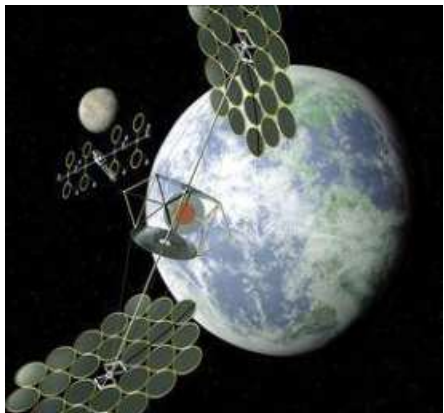
Q: What is space-based solar power?

A: The Shimizu Corporation in Japan has proposed a belt of power plants sitting along the moon’s equator, which is 11,000 km long, called the “Lunar Ring”. According to the company’s plans, robots can build this mega-structure from lunar soil. The facilities will collect solar energy from the sun and beam it to the earth as microwaves.

If space-based solar power sounds like science fiction, it is exactly that. The concept involves launching large arrays of satellites to collect sunlight 24/7, and beaming the energy to the earth as microwave radiation. The corporation’s plans are slightly different — they involve facilities on the lunar surface rather than in earth orbit — but otherwise involve the same physics.

Unfortunately for supporters of the idea, there are daunting hurdles. The cost of space-based solar is staggering. Even if rocket launch prices drop significantly, engineers must still transport thousands of tonnes of hardware into orbit (or the moon). Building a single functional power plant is an unprecedented logistical feat. Once operational, the system must beam power through the atmosphere, a process that will lose significant energy as heat.

In orbit, a single collision with space debris could cripple a billion-dollar array, turning it into junk. Maintenance



A conceptual illustration of a satellite collecting solar energy in earth orbit and beaming it down as microwaves. NASA

will also be extremely expensive on the moon.

Terrestrial solar and battery storage are also getting cheaper and more efficient every year, making it hard to justify a complex and risky orbital or lunar facility. For now, space-based solar remains an idea trapped in poor economics.



For feedback and suggestions for ‘Science’, please write to **science@thehindu.co.in** with the subject ‘Daily page’

Text & Context

THE HINDU

NEWS IN NUMBERS

Crops damaged due to unseasonal rains in Maharashtra

2.05 in lakh hectares. Unseasonal rains and hailstorms have damaged crops on more than 2.05 lakh hectares of land in Maharashtra, officials from the agriculture department said on Tuesday. According to preliminary estimates, crops on 1.22 lakh hectares were damaged in the second half of March, and 82,704 hectares in early April. PTI

Flights cancelled by Indian carriers to West Asia since war began

10,000 Over 10,000 flights by Indian carriers to West Asia have been cancelled since the war broke out in the region, a senior civil aviation ministry official said on Tuesday. Flights to West Asia by Indian carriers have come down to around 80-90, Joint Secretary, Ministry of Civil Aviation, Asangba Chuba Ao, said. PTI

U.K.'s cap on interest rates for student loans from September 2026

6 in per cent. Britain said on Tuesday that it would cap interest rates on millions of student loans at 6 per cent from September 2026, saying conflict in West Asia risked pushing up inflation and sharply increasing borrowing cost. The student loan system in England and Wales has drawn criticism and Prime Minister Keir Starmer had said that he would look at ways to make it fairer. REUTERS

Number of weeks for which TRP reporting has been withheld

4 The government has extended for four weeks its order to withhold the reporting of Television Rating Points (TRPs) for TV news channels to “curb display of sensationalism and speculative content” amidst the West Asia conflict. The Ministry of Information and Broadcasting had on March 6 issued the first directive to Broadcast Audience Research Council to withhold reporting of the TRPs. PTI

The share of women in the electoral roll of Assam

49.98 in per cent. Women nearly equal their male counterparts in the electoral rolls of Assam and outnumber them in 16 out of the 35 districts, but they constitute a mere 59 out of the 722 candidates in the fray for the Assembly polls. Women outnumber men in campaign rallies and meetings. PTI
COMPILED BY THE HINDU DATA TEAM

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On India’s updated climate pledges

India’s announcement of its revised Nationally Determined Contributions (NDCs) to the Paris Agreement prompts scrutiny of its existing climate mitigation actions and the need to factor in the country’s developmental costs alongside those of meeting its climate commitments

FULL CONTEXT

T. Jayaraman

India’s announcement of its revised Nationally Determined Contributions (NDCs) to the Paris Agreement – the term applied to the mitigation and other climate action targets that countries voluntarily commit to under the agreement – represents a considered step forward when India’s energy and development policies are encountering serious headwinds. It is clear that the government has opted for continuity and incremental advance with respect to India’s earlier NDCs. It is also clearly confident that its commitments will nevertheless be more than adequate in relation to its equitable share of global climate action, in keeping with climate justice and within its expected commitments as a developing nation.

Three climate goals

As the press communique after the Cabinet approval of the updated NDCs noted, there are three specific enhancements that have been committed. The first is an increase in the reduction of emissions intensity of its GDP, from 45% below 2005 levels by 2030 to 47% below 2005 levels by 2035. The second is ensuring that 60% of installed capacity for power generation is from non-fossil fuel sources, while the third is the enhancement of forest and tree cover carbon sinks to 3.5 - 4 billion tonnes of carbon dioxide equivalent above 2005 levels.

India’s climate policies are best understood in the context of its structural constraints as a lower middle income developing country, that determine its available choices for climate action. Over the last three decades, these constraints have not substantially changed, which is also why India continues to insist on the relevance of the United Nations Framework Convention on Climate Change (UNFCCC). But apart from these, given the structure of the Paris Agreement that requires renewed and enhanced commitments to climate mitigation every five years, short-term considerations have also begun to have a considerable weight in the formulation of the NDCs. The rapid deterioration of the global environment for climate action over the last year has undoubtedly brought this issue to the fore.

Enthusiasm for climate action

Structural constraints have not, however, dampened enthusiasm for climate action in India, both at the level of the Centre and the State governments. There is a considerable range of activities designed to set India on the path to low-carbon development, drawing significant public and private sector efforts and resources, including electric vehicles, enhancement of energy efficiency, promotion and deployment of non-fossil fuel sources of electricity generation, new technologies such as green hydrogen and more recently, the active promotion of carbon capture and storage efforts.

But given India’s developmental levels today, it is clearly premature for India to convert all such efforts into the significantly more onerous and accountable commitments that are the NDCs, the progress towards which is to be reported every two years in the Biennial Transparency Report (BTR) to the UNFCCC.

A section of global and domestic public opinion has raised the issue of the



A drone view of solar panels and the NTPC (National Thermal Power Corporation) power plant in Solapur, Maharashtra. REUTERS

adequacy of India’s NDCs relative to a global temperature goal of 1.5 degree warming above pre-industrial levels (the more ambitious part of the Paris Agreement’s goals). Some have downplayed the new targets, one commentator going so far as to call it “a walk in the park”. Others call for increased generation from renewables as the metric and not installed capacity. Even some sections of opinion that have welcomed the NDCs, appear nevertheless to be uncertain on whether these new commitments are genuinely the best that India can make at this time.

The cost of going green

All the above variants of the “India can (must) do more argument” ignore some critical realities that contextualise India’s climate actions. Given that India’s natural energy source is overwhelmingly coal, it is inaccurate to view improvements in emissions efficiency of GDP and the corresponding bending of its emissions trajectory as a “natural” corollary of India’s growth story. Priority to electricity from renewable sources comes with significant costs, including backing down readily available and often cheaper or comparably priced coal-based thermal power, further tilting a playing field that privileges renewable energy to sustain our climate commitments.

Renewable energy (RE) projects including utility scale battery storage have begun to make their appearance in India’s power sector. But the corresponding scaling up of India’s battery storage capacity, required for ensuring the stability of generation even from the proposed 2030 RE targets will run into a few trillion rupees at least. Part of such expansion would have to be funded by the government, deploying resources that would have been utilised in other sectors. At the very least, the deployment of such large-scale battery systems is not immediately feasible. The most globally

widespread option of energy storage in reverse pumped hydropower systems, has very limited scope in India at present. Additionally, environmental concerns, and water needs for competing uses such as irrigation, as well as the regulatory challenges faced by all large hydro projects are likely to preclude any rapid expansion.

Optimistic RE projections, not only in India but even globally, have run into the lack of transmission capacity and the challenges of grid balancing, with the associated costs often omitted when referring to the cost-effectiveness of RE power.

Since, for India, coal is the mainstay of power generation when solar and wind cease, unlike the large-scale gas and hydro available elsewhere, the full utilisation of the available RE capacity will inevitably have to be “curtailed”, while adding to the operation and maintenance costs for thermal power operated in this cyclical fashion. These add further to the true cost that India bears for the pursuit of its climate commitments.

Improving energy efficiency in other sectors is also being pursued vigorously, including the introduction of mandatory emissions intensity targets in key industries. The early ramp up of electric vehicles, while the jump from BSIV to BSVI vehicle emissions standards was just coming into place, was another leap-frog moment, whose cost to the economy must not be underestimated. Since the 26th Conference of Parties of the United Nations Framework on Climate Change at Glasgow, every Central government budget has seen a range of initiatives and resource commitment across various aspects of climate mitigation. Indeed, a major knowledge gap today is that while future costs of increased mitigation action are routinely calculated, the cost burden attached to India’s mitigation initiatives undertaken so far, in the absence of any significant climate finance, have yet to be

estimated in a reliable manner.

Accounting for India’s developmental future

At a more over-arching level, India’s mitigation challenge cannot be based on a simple extrapolation of the current structural features and trends of its economy.

India’s developmental future needs room for further large-scale growth in manufacturing and industry, expansion in the provision of goods and services to its population at adequate levels beyond the minimum, and an urban transition that has only just begun. In this context, the “India can do more” arguments that rely on such extrapolation of economic trends and the persistence of current structural features, miss the urgent need to hedge India’s developmental future.

India cannot commit its NDCs to preserving the Paris Agreement goal of limiting global temperature increase to 1.5 degrees above pre-industrial levels, when the goal is rapidly slipping out of reach. This a trend that India cannot reverse, given that its per capita emissions are a third of the global average. Even otherwise, under the voluntary emissions reduction NDCs of the Paris Agreement, the benefits of India’s reduction in emissions below any business-as-usual baseline, are distributed primarily to the big emitters globally, due to their inadequate efforts, and proportionately less to India, especially when the largest historical emitter has walked out of all climate treaties and seeks to dismantle climate action both at home and abroad

India’s climate commitments have to be strategic and circumspect, while its NDCs are formulated in informed self-awareness of its, to use the language of the Paris Agreement, “national circumstances.”

(T. Jayaraman is with the National Institute of Advanced Studies, Bengaluru. Views expressed are personal.)

THE GIST

India’s climate policies are best understood in the context of its structural constraints as a lower middle-income developing country, which shape its choices for climate action.

The country has implemented several decarbonisation initiatives, including electric vehicles, deployment of non-fossil fuel power sources, and technologies such as green hydrogen.

However, India needs room for further large-scale growth in manufacturing and industry, which must be factored in alongside the future costs of its climate commitments.

